The Quiet Cost

A Stepparent's Journey Through Parental Alienation

By: K. E. Laine

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Dedication

This book took shape through shared
strength and steady belief—
through family who stood beside me,
friends who knew my truth and listened without judgment,
and trusted voices who gave their time, care, and skill to edit
my words and help bring this book into being.
Because of you, this work exists, and my life is richer for it.

Table of Contents

Preface……..…….13

Introduction……..…….……19

Chapter 1: Walking into the Middle ..……..…….23

Chapter 2: Parental Alienation…….….27

Chapter 3: When Time Stopped Being Ours…….……35

Chapter 4: When Boundaries Became Battles…….47

Chapter 5: The Mirror of Jealousy……59

Chapter 6: False Claims and False Realities……67

Chapter 7: Silent Manipulation……..…79

Chapter 8: The Quiet Divide……..……87

Chapter 9: The Weekend That Changed Everything…….……93

Chapter 10: What We Carry Forward……..…….. 105

Poem: *The Quiet Cost*……*113*

Echoes of Understanding: Discovering Truth…..……115

Resources: Scripts and Templates …….121

Resources: Leading Experts……149

Checklist: Parental Alienation Behavior Checklist…….……154

PREFACE

I always believed family was unshakable, until I realized that loyalty, love, and trust can be tested in ways no parent is ever prepared for.

My husband and I have two boys together, and he has two sons from a previous marriage. We both come from families that instilled in us values, morals, and a deep sense of belonging. These are the principles that have become the foundation of our marriage and our parenting. Our lives are rich with traditions, celebrations, and the simple joys of family. From holidays and birthdays to vacations and everyday moments, we cherish the time spent together, honoring the past while creating new memories. This support system has truly been our lifeline over the past fifteen years, standing beside us as we continue to fight for our voice as parents amid the challenges we have faced.

I am not a clinician or a doctor. I am a teacher, a mother, and a stepparent who has been deeply involved in my stepchildren's lives since they were two and four years old. I have cared for their well-being, supported their education, and helped nurture their interests, all while honoring my role as a stepparent and respecting the bond they have with their biological mother. What follows is raw, emotional, and unfinished. Every experience I share is supported by fifteen years of well-documented accounts through emails, texts, and conversations, which became my lifeline amidst the chaos.

Although the majority of this book revolves around my older stepson, my younger stepson's story is woven in more quietly, both because he is still a minor and out of respect for the privacy of his own personal struggles. Readers should understand, however, that he, too, has been deeply affected by parental alienation. His battle is ongoing, unfolding more subtly as he works through the root causes of his anxiety and begins to name what he has endured.

The research I reference comes from years of observation, reflection, and personal study through books, podcasts, and articles. This is a personal memoir, grounded in my life experiences

and reflections as a parent and stepparent. No names are used, and conversations are paraphrased or reconstructed from memory rather than quoted verbatim. The perspectives, feelings, and interpretations in this book are my own and offered in the spirit of truth, healing, and understanding. Certain details, timelines, and characteristics have been changed or blended to protect privacy, while still giving my own lived experience. This is my attempt as a stepmom to illuminate what it feels like to watch loyalty, love, and family bonds shift under the pressure of manipulation, so that other parents and stepparents may recognize the signs and act before it is too late.

INTRODUCTION

Fifteen years into my life as a stepmother, I found myself in conversation with my nineteen-year-old stepson, now an adult in college. What he said did not come loudly, but it did not come gently either. It was measured, deliberate, edged with something I recognized immediately. It was not anger, exactly, but there was something quietly cruel in the way it landed. It came plainly, almost offhand, as if the thought had been shaped for him.

"I have no memory of my mom and dad together," he said. "But I think I never had time to adjust to having a stepmom."

The sentence landed with weight. It confirmed what a year of hard discovery had been assembling piece by piece, and it became the axis on which this story turns. A story still in motion, still unfolding, still asking to be understood.

To anyone from the outside looking in, there was no obvious conflict. There was no yelling, no shouting, no name-calling, no public bashing. The children were never exposed to firsthand scenes of hostility. From the surface, it appeared as though two co-parents managed their relationship reasonably well with a friendly stepparent that was equally involved. But what we endured did not live in public spaces. The abuse was passive, persistent, and relentless. It unfolded quietly, behind closed doors, in the safety of texts, emails, insinuations, threats disguised as concern, and manipulation subtle enough to evade detection but powerful enough to erode trust over time.

When I first discovered the term *parental alienation*, my life flashed before my eyes. Page after page, story after story, it was not just familiar, it was us. We were not another blended family struggling through a difficult transition or clashing parenting styles. We were unmistakably living a textbook case of parental alienation. Every example mirrored our reality. All of the feelings I had buried, questioned, or second-guessed were suddenly validated. It was a moment of clarity so sharp it felt electric, as if I wanted to scream it from the rooftops. However that validation came like a crashing wave. How had we not seen it? Why had counselors, the court, or anyone failed to call it what it was? Why

did it take months of self-reflection, research, and late-night podcasts to finally name what we were experiencing? Why was it only after my oldest stepson walked out the door for what was supposed to be a normal week at his mother's, and never returned, that the truth finally surfaced?

Our journey began fifteen years ago. Fifteen years of small erasures, strained exchanges, invisible battles, and heartbreaking shifts in the children we love. Fifteen years of navigating a maze we did not know had a map. And still, our story is far from over. We live inside it every day.

That is why I am writing this book. Other parents and stepparents deserve to know that what they are feeling is not imagined. That the knot in their stomach, the sense of being forgotten, the slow severing of connections they once had with their children are not just emotions, they are real. Often, they are signs of emotional abuse, directed not only at the targeted parent but also at the children themselves. If sharing our story brings awareness to even one child, helps one family put language to what they are living, or protects one child from being weaponized, that alone gives this story its purpose.

This is not a story of resolution. It is a story of endurance. It is a story of truth told from one stepparent's perspective. One taken *from the outside, looking in*. This is a story that I hope, in sharing with you, allows you to feel less alone in your own story.

CHAPTER 1
Walking Into the Middle

I never expected that stepping into love would also mean stepping into a war I did not start. When I met my husband, I knew he came with children, and it did not scare me. I am a teacher who works with kids every day, and I have seen wonderful examples of blended families. I pictured dinners around the table, shared holidays, maybe even the kind of chaos that feels like love. What I did not picture was how invisible I could feel in a house full of people. The first sign came before we were even married.

We were planning the wedding, and I was full of hope, dreaming not just about joining my life with my husband's, but also about becoming part of his boys' lives. We had been living together for six months with his shared parenting schedule, and we were learning the ins and outs of being a family. Two days before the wedding, my husband received a call from his ex-wife. She said she did not want the boys at our wedding, that they were too young to choose if they wanted to be there, and that it was unfair of him to put them in that situation at two and five years old. It was such an untimely call. Why would my husband's children, my future stepchildren, not want to be part of our wedding? Why would they not be part of their dad's joy, his family, his new beginning? I brushed it off at first, telling myself it was just stress or nerves or complicated co-parenting dynamics. But deep down, I felt the sting. It was the first time I realized someone else was already drawing lines around what role I was allowed to have in my stepchildren's lives. It was a decision being forced upon me without any input from my husband, the children, or myself.

In the beginning, the boys were excited to see me. They were young, carefree, open to love and connection. They would run through the door full of stories, full of energy, happy to be together. But slowly, over the years, that changed. The greetings faded. The warmth cooled. Soon they would walk right past me without a word, as if I were invisible in my own home. It only took a few years before the shift started to become noticeable, they were happy to see dad but it was almost like someone told them not to

acknowledge me.

I will never forget one moment with my oldest stepson. He looked me straight in the eyes and said, “You are like a mom to us, because you do everything a mom does… but you are not a mom.” I did not know how to respond. In one sentence, he acknowledged me and then, with a single phrase, removed me from existence. I was not asking to replace anyone, but I also could not deny what I felt. I was being written out of my own story before it had even begun. Even the word stepmom felt off-limits, as if using it would invite anger or rejection. I had no title, no name for my place, just the weight of doing everything, loving, caring, showing up, while being told directly and indirectly that I did not matter. Even in front of their mother, she instructed the boys to call me “Miss,” a formality that felt cold and deliberately inauthentic.

Looking back, I see now that parental alienation does not start with shouting or accusations. It starts quietly. Whispers from a parent that fill a child’s head with thoughts of exclusion, withholding recognition, and ultimately starting the slow erasure of your existence or importance. Before you know it, you are expected to fulfill a central role in the life of a family you desperately want to love while remaining invisible. Unseen. Forgotten.

CHAPTER 2
Parental Alienation

For years, I thought what we were living was just a high-conflict co-parenting situation or maybe the unfortunate reality of divorce and blended families. But when I stumbled across the term parental alienation and the clinical description of it, my heart stopped. We were not living something unusual or unique. We were living something that had a name.

Parental alienation is a process in which one parent deliberately or unconsciously undermines and damages a child's relationship with the other parent. It goes far beyond occasional badmouthing or disagreements between adults. It is a consistent pattern of manipulation, distortion, and emotional conditioning, designed intentionally or not, to make the child distance themselves, reject, or even despise the targeted parent. Psychiatrist Dr. Richard Gardner first introduced the term parental alienation syndrome in the 1980s to describe children who unjustifiably rejected one parent as a result of the other parent's influence. While the term syndrome is now less commonly used, the underlying behaviors and resulting emotional abuse remain central to how professionals understand and identify parental alienation today.

Modern researchers and clinicians describe parental alienation as a form of psychological abuse that can profoundly affect a child's sense of safety, identity, and reality. The alienating parent often uses tactics such as exaggerating faults, rewriting history, fostering fear or guilt, controlling narratives, and rewarding rejection of the other parent. Over time, the child may internalize these distortions so completely that the rejection feels self-generated rather than influenced.

In short, parental alienation occurs when a child is pulled into a loyalty conflict so powerful that they begin to reject a loving and capable parent who has done nothing to warrant the loss. The tragedy lies in the fact that the child's belief in their own rejection feels entirely real, even though it has been shaped by another's manipulation. Alienation does not usually begin with dramatic outbursts. It creeps in slowly, almost invisibly, until one day you realize the child in front of you is no longer seeing you clearly but

through someone else's filter. To an outsider, these behaviors can look like teen rebellion or kids adjusting to divorce. But to those of us living it, the pattern is unmistakable. It is a systematic erasure, not natural distance. Parental alienation is confusing because it targets both the child and the parent. The child feels pressure, guilt, and fear, taught that love is conditional. The targeted parent feels heartbreak, helplessness, and rage, watching their relationship dissolve while being told it is their fault.

For me, as a stepparent, the pain was double-edged. I watched my husband be erased, and I also felt myself disappearing in the process. I was once greeted with joy, even called *like* a mom. But then the warmth froze. I became invisible. No matter how much I gave, I was told in both subtle and obvious ways that I did not count. Not inside our home, but by someone determined to believe that her children had room to love only one parent.

This is why naming it matters. When I first read the definition of parental alienation, my life clicked into place. What felt chaotic and personal had a pattern. We were not imagining situations. This was a recognized form of emotional abuse. Naming it does not fix it, but it validates your reality. It tells you that you are not imagining this and you are not alone.

The moment you name alienation, you stop blaming yourself. When you stop blaming yourself, you can begin the work of survival and the slow work of healing.

Signs You Might Be Experiencing Parental Alienation

Sudden unexplained rejection: Your child begins to pull away or show hostility without any clear reason or triggering event.

Rewriting of history: Your child starts to recall past events inaccurately, exaggerating small mistakes or inventing new wrongs that never happened.

Loss of warmth and affection: The child who once showed love, trust, and connection now seems cold, distant, or indifferent toward you.

One-sided loyalty: Your child defends the other parent no matter what, while finding fault with everything you do, even neutral or positive actions.

Adult-like language or accusations: Your child begins using words, tone, or ideas that sound more like the other parent's voice than their own.

Refusal of contact or visitation: The child resists phone calls, visits, or time together and may say things like "I don't want to see you," without a clear reason or explanation.

Unfounded fear or guilt: Your child expresses fear, anxiety, or guilt around spending time with you, even though there is no evidence of mistreatment or danger.

Rejection of extended family: Your child also withdraws from your relatives, grandparents, cousins, or siblings, acting as if they are part of the problem too.

Constant criticism: Everything you say or do is met with sarcasm, suspicion, or contempt, while the other parent is idealized or can do no wrong.

Lack of empathy for your feelings: Your child seems unmoved by your pain or confusion, often echoing alienating narratives such as "You deserve it" or "You never cared about me."

Coaching or scripting: You notice your child repeating the same phrases, timing, or accusations in ways that feel rehearsed.

Conditional love: Your relationship with your child starts to feel transactional, based on whether you agree with or act in alignment with the alienating parent's agenda.

Ways Parental Alienation Shows Up for Stepparents

Being treated as an outsider: The alienating parent paints you as an intruder or replacement, convincing the child that your presence threatens their bond with the other parent. Even small gestures of care may be twisted as overstepping.

Disrespect or emotional withdrawal from the stepchild: The child may begin to mimic the alienating parent's dismissive or hostile attitude toward you, refusing to engage, avoiding eye contact, or being overtly rude.

Subtle exclusion from family relationships: The alienating parent may encourage the child to refer to the real family versus them, reinforcing the idea that you are temporary or unworthy of connection.

Rewriting your role: Your contributions, such as meals cooked, help with schoolwork, and attending games, may be minimized or reframed as controlling, manipulative, or unnecessary.

Triangulation through the child: The child is used to deliver hurtful messages or compare households, repeating the alienating parent's narrative to keep you and your spouse on the defensive.

Emotional distancing of your partner: The stress of alienation can pull your spouse into guilt or conflict with you, especially if the child resists visits or becomes withdrawn.

Being blamed for the alienation: The alienating parent may accuse you of causing the child's rejection, claiming that things were fine until you entered the picture.

Sudden changes in the child's comfort level: A stepchild who once joked with you, accepted help, or sought comfort may suddenly become cold, distant, or angry, reflecting external influence rather than genuine resentment.

Social or public exclusion: The alienating parent might deliberately omit you from school events, communication loops, or celebrations, reinforcing to the child and others that you do not belong.

Strain on your own sense of place: You may begin to doubt your instincts, feel unseen in your own home, or question whether showing love will make things worse.

In essence:

Parental alienation for stepparents is often a slow erasure of connection, of belonging, and of truth. You feel the chill of rejection that is not truly yours to own. The goal of the alienating parent is not only to divide the child from their biological parent but to fracture the entire sense of safety and unity in the blended family.

CHAPTER 3
When Time Stopped Being Ours

In the beginning, the changes were almost imperceptible and unnoticeable at times. Looking back now, knowing what I know about parental alienation, I can see how quickly it all began to unravel. Small slights or isolated conflicts at the time were actually the earliest threads being pulled from our family fabric.

I had already heard the stories of my husband's life with his ex. The ups and downs. The qualities that had once seemed tolerable but ultimately left him unhappy. The constant control. The overbearing family influence. The one-sided unfairness that bled into every corner of their marriage. He wanted more for himself, but most of all for his boys. He did not want them growing up in a home where being taken advantage of was mistaken for love, where silence passed as peace, and where respect was always one-sided.

When I came into his life, I carried an open mind. His experiences with his ex-wife had not happened to me. I was not the one who had lived through the manipulation or endured the slow grind of control. What I saw was a man standing in front of me who wanted to create a healthier life. Someone who believed his children deserved to grow up knowing fairness, love, and stability. Someone who wanted his children to learn that true love is respect and compromise, woven into the small everyday choices of being a team.

From the beginning, we promised ourselves we would co-parent with his ex, putting the boys first and offering good faith even when it was not returned. At the time, it felt like what adults do for the sake of their children. I realize now it was a vow rooted in hope and kept alive by endurance, even when it quietly broke us. The truth was, the unraveling had already begun, and the hill we started climbing would soon become Mt. Everest.

From my perspective as a stepparent, I often watched the strongest version of my husband, the steady, confident, and unwavering man, disappear the moment she asked or demanded something. In those moments, he became a shell of himself, giving in almost instantly. It frustrated me deeply because I could see so

clearly what was happening. His ex-wife was using the same power and control she once held over him in their marriage, and he was still reacting as if he had to live with the consequences. I reminded him often, "You do not live with her anymore. You do not have to brace for the fallout. We can stand our ground." Despite all this, we vowed to remain flexible and not lose sight of what was important: the kids.

At first, the worst of it seemed to be the constant micromanaging of our home. Small interruptions, subtle scheduling tricks. She would plan events on our days or suddenly remember an obligation that required her to pick up the boys mid-visit. More often than not, it was a family birthday party that conveniently fell on my husband's birthday. She would frame it as reasonable, asking if they could attend both celebrations.

My husband would hesitate, reminding her that we had our own plans, but eventually the guilt set in. We were made to feel selfish if we did not allow the boys to attend her family's function during our scheduled parenting time. We told ourselves we were doing the right thing, that giving in spared the boys from conflict. If we did not have something concrete planned, what harm could it do?

What we did not yet understand was that every small concession gave the impression that our voice was not important. We told ourselves it was cooperation. We told ourselves it was maturity. The truth was that generosity was never reciprocated.

On the rare occasions when we asked for the same courtesy, whether for a family gathering or to bring the boys to an event that happened to fall on her scheduled time, it would not work out. It was always her time, always her rules. One night stands out with painful clarity. Our oldest son had contracted impetigo. He was uncomfortable, tired, and clearly needed to rest. My husband offered to keep him overnight on her night so he could recover and relax while she and her family attended a festival with the younger sibling and her family. She refused outright. Instead of allowing his dad to care for him for even one extra night, she insisted on

taking him to the festival. He was miserable the entire evening, dragged along not because it was in his best interest, but because giving his father that time would mean conceding control and giving him more than she thought he deserved. The lesson was quiet but cruel. Their father's love could be diminished, disregarded, or even erased in the moment it was needed.

She never gave us any more time than the shared parenting agreement allowed. Even when she was out of town, she would have her parents watch the boys instead of letting them stay with us. When my husband asked, she insisted her parents had the right to watch the boys on her nights, reinforcing a message the children absorbed: *When Mom is gone, you need Grandma and Grandpa, not your dad.* That message only hardened with time, slowly erasing our home and any importance it held.

It felt like everything in our lives started revolving around what she wanted the boys to do, even when it was not her parenting time. She would deliberately sign them up for clubs, activities, and events during our days, cutting into the little time we had to be together as a family. It was not about the boys having opportunities, as she would say to anyone who would listen. It was about making sure our time with them never belonged fully to us. She couldn't handle not having full autonomy over their life. She pretended she was trying to work with my husband, but working with him only meant agreeing with whatever she wanted and she never wanted a teammate.

As a teacher, I know the importance of giving children space to grow through activities, clubs, and new adventures that widen their world. I also know the equal weight of quiet moments, of time spent together as a family, building the bonds that hold us steady. In a blended family, that balance is no longer in the hands of one parent nor contained within a single household. It requires shared choices and shared voices. Yet she could not bear that truth. To her, parenting was not meant to be shared. Parenting was hers to control, hers to command, and anything less felt like loss.

As a stepparent, I never felt silenced by my husband. He values my thoughts, my instincts, my place beside him in our family. But with her, it was different. I had no standing, no authority of my own. My voice could never arrive directly. It had to be carried through my husband, softened or reframed, so it might be tolerated. Every suggestion I offered became his concern or his idea, never mine. It left me in a strange in-between place, present, committed, deeply invested yet invisible in eyes that refused to see me. I lived in that quiet tension, knowing my love and effort were real, but my influence was hidden and cast aside by her manipulation.

When my husband spoke up, when he said a certain club did not work for our schedule or asked to adjust the plans, she twisted it. Suddenly, my husband was being accused of keeping them from having friends or withholding them from experiences. She would complain that we lived too far away and we were keeping them from their life in her city, the same city where we were both teachers.

It was exhausting and unfair, and my husband was made out to be unreasonable for wanting to spend quality time with his kids. In reality, we lived twelve miles apart, about a fifteen to twenty-minute drive. The boys had strong friendships in our neighborhood, a sense of belonging in our community, and time with extended family. None of it mattered. Our involvement exposed the cracks in the claims she made about us. She was not fostering connection in the same ways, and that imbalance threatened her sense of control. So she chipped away at our family time, ensured it was always overshadowed by her presence, and eventually planted the belief that we lived too far away for the boys to sustain friendships in her neighborhood or school. She hovered over every corner of our lives, at every event she orchestrated and demanded the kids attend.

We never asked her not to attend events during our parenting time, but we did expect common courtesy. Instead, our weekends were often overshadowed by her presence. At sports games, even

when the boys' grandparents were visiting, she would sweep in, walk directly to where we were sitting, lift the youngest from whichever lap he was on, and carry him away so he could be with her and away from us.

One day, my husband finally spoke up. He said, "My parents are only here for the day, and it means a lot for them to have this time with the boys. You will have them for the next four days, so I would appreciate it if you could respect my time with them the same way I respect yours."

Her response cut through the air like a blade. She said, "How dare you say I cannot be around *my* children."

That single sentence revealed the pattern that would follow us for years. What started as her right to be at a sporting event quickly evolved into doing whatever she pleased under the banner of *her* rights as their mother. They were *her* children.

The irony was that we were never trying to keep the boys from her. We only asked for respect for our time, just as we respected hers. We asked for Dad to have his time too. She was welcome at every sports game, every school event and every child-related activity. All we wanted was the chance to share those moments with family without her pulling the strings and overshadowing our presence.

In her eyes, any boundary was an attack, and any request for fairness was bullying. From that day forward, the word bully became her weapon of choice. For years, any disagreement, no matter how small, was shut down by her raising her voice, pointing her finger, and declaring my husband a bully.

The word froze conversations in their tracks, casting my husband as the aggressor when all he had done was ask for respect or express an opinion that did not align with hers. Just four months into our marriage, I finally said aloud what I had been holding inside: something was not okay. The convenient forgetting of dates, the constant control, and the way her manipulation changed his demeanor whenever she pushed her way through. It was not random, and it was not innocent. It was deliberate. I

urged him to start saving every message and every exchange, because I knew we were no longer dealing with misunderstandings but with a damaging pattern.

So we did. We saved every single email, every text, and, knowing our right, every conversation.*. The boys were only Six and three years old when we started documentation and we have continued ever since. At the time, it felt exhausting, even paranoid. However, later, those documents became our lifeline. It was evidence of what had really been happening behind the curtain of co-parenting.

**My state is a one-party consent state. This means that under my state's law, only one person involved in a conversation needs to consent to its recording. If you participate in a conversation, you can legally record it without notifying the other party. This applies to in-person, telephone, and digital conversations, including video chats.*

On the Outside Looking In: Subtle Signs

Scheduling Overlap: The other parent is signing kids up for activities, clubs, or events that consistently fall during your parenting time.

What you can do: Keep a calendar of your parenting schedule and track overlaps. If a pattern emerges, bring it up calmly in writing, asking for balance. Suggest alternatives such as switching weeks or choosing neutral activities so the kids do not have to miss out, but your time is not erased.

Last Minute Changes: They frequently announce new plans, events, or obligations at the last minute that interfere with your scheduled time.

What you can do: Respond with calm firmness, saying, "That does not work for us with this little notice." Do not feel pressured to say yes just because it is framed as urgent. Document these instances so the emergencies reveal themselves as a pattern, not exceptions.

One-Sided Flexibility: You are expected to adjust your schedule for their plans, but they rarely or never agree to adjust for yours.

What you can do: Stop giving in every time. Flexibility is healthy, but it must go both ways. When you say no kindly but firmly, you teach that boundaries are not up for negotiation. Keep a record of when you bent and when they did not. It will help if guilt sets in.

Guilt or Accusations: If you push back, they accuse you of keeping the kids from opportunities, isolating them from friends,

or not supporting their interests. They may call you unreasonable, a bully, a threat, or worthless.

What you can do: Refuse to argue labels. Respond only to the facts, not the insults. A BIFF (Brief, Informative, Friendly, Firm) response works. Insults lose their power when you do not engage.

Undermining Your Home or Community: They dismiss or devalue the friendships, activities, or opportunities the kids have in your home, neighborhood, or school district.

What you can do: Continue building stability quietly. Invite friends over, sign kids up for local teams, and show consistency. Kids eventually recognize stability for what it is.

Presence in Your Time: They show up at events or activities during your parenting time and take over the attention of the children, so you never truly have space as a family.

What you can do: Set respectful but firm boundaries if needed. Document repeated interruptions. If it escalates, suggest neutral agreements through mediation, such as separate seating at events.

Control Through the Children: Kids are told directly or indirectly that they will miss out if they follow your schedule, making them feel guilty for being with you. They may be told you live too far away, even if distance is not a factor.

What you can do: Reassure the kids that their life does not have to be either or. Keep your message steady. Document statements that reveal manipulation.

Isolation of Family Time: Family meals, downtime, or traditions get pushed aside because their plans take priority, leaving little unstructured time together.

What you can do: Protect rituals, even small ones. Name them as traditions. Kids remember the consistency.

Pattern Over Time: It becomes the norm that their plans dictate your parenting time.

What you can do: Keep written records to clearly demonstrate the pattern. Use the documented timeline to advocate for consistency.

Chapter 4
When Boundaries Became Battles

There comes a point in every difficult journey when you realize that love alone is not enough; you need boundaries to survive. The next chapter of our journey was about creating those boundaries. You hear about setting healthy boundaries all of the time, but truthfully, it is something we had no experience with in a co-parenting environment. No one gave us any advice, there were no handbooks, and of course, we did not have any of the knowledge we now have about parental alienation. All we had was a strong intuition that something was not right and that the changes in the boys were impacting our household. Simply put, something needed to change. Our time, our money, and our sanity were being tested beyond measure. Setting boundaries felt like throwing pebbles into a storm. Every attempt to clarify schedules, protect family time, and our insistence on mutual respect was met with resistance. Sometimes it was icy silence; other times, overt threats of lawyers, escalating conflicts, or full-blown adult temper tantrums. Nothing we tried seemed to work. It was exhausting and demoralizing. Each effort to assert a small measure of control over our own lives seemed to intensify her tactics. It did not seem to matter that we would bend over backwards to assure her, and show her how the changes we recommended were designed to make everyone's lives easier and to provide more stability for the boys. Even in the face of this, we had to keep trying, for the boys, for our sanity, and to maintain some semblance of order in a world that felt entirely dictated by her whims.

We quickly learned that setting boundaries was not a one-time act. It was a constant, grueling negotiation, often with no immediate reward, but without it, the chaos would have consumed us entirely. Her need to dictate how my husband spent time with the boys never stopped. She began insisting on one-on-one nights, claiming it was about quality time, but what was important at that time for us was being together as a new blended family. Instead, it was quite clear that her behavior was a shallow veiled attempt to micromanage our time with the boys. She also began creating a pattern where she always had to top anything we

did. It soon became evident that if we had plans to do something special with the boys, then she was going to top it or completely dismiss their joy over time spent with us. We did our best not to let it bother us, as our focus was on carving out family time of our own, navigating a new marriage, new co-parenting dynamics, and simply wanting the boys to see us as a unified family. But no matter what, my husband was always framed as the bad guy. If he did not agree, it meant he did not love them enough.

To anyone reading, you may ask why we always just gave in. I wish I had an answer. It felt like we had no choice. I do not even fully understand why we felt this way; we just did. We wanted to keep the calm, we wanted to live our lives without constant interruption and strain, so we moved through each day like shadows, present but restrained, trying to protect our family while constantly aware that the space we had, the love we offered, was being systematically undermined. Every small victory felt borrowed, every plan fragile, as if our own hearts had to bend just to keep the peace.

Once, she told my husband directly, "The boys don't have a relationship with you because when they were young, I spent time with them while you were off doing other things." She was implying that my presence was the reason he failed to form a relationship with his children, as though my entrance into his life somehow replaced or erased his love for them. I sat there listening to her on speaker phone. She did not know I was there, but by this point in our life, I always listened in to take notes and make sure we always had two accounts of what was going on. My stomach twisted. I wanted to shout, to defend him, to tell her she had no idea what she was saying and to stop with the overt accusations or presumed assumptions. It would not have mattered because she had no interest in the truth. She only wanted to tear him down. As a stepparent, this was one of the hardest things I had ever faced. I could see the truth, and I felt the love he gave to the boys every single day. Regardless, I was unable to defend him as I had no direct voice in the room. My role was to support my husband and

to provide guidance where I could, but most importantly, my role was to remain silent as I felt I could not have a voice in the matter. Every insult, every false claim, landed in my chest like a weight I could not move. I was fully invested, yet powerless, caught between witnessing the injustice and knowing there was nothing I could say that would matter to her. Her belief was her own, twisted in the jealousy that she tried to hide.

One day, my oldest stepson said, "Mom and Grandma want to know whose house I have more fun at and who I love more." We were stunned. We told him what we knew was right. He did not have to choose. Loving both parents was not only possible but healthy, and there was joy to be found in both homes. It was eye-opening and heartbreaking. This was not just her. It was her mother, too. It became clear we were not just dealing with a difficult co-parent. We were up against a generational pattern of control and manipulation. Her own mother, the boys' grandmother, fueled the message just as much as she did and would continue to over the years. We were barred from everyday moments that define parenting. Haircuts were tightly controlled, scheduled and managed by their grandmother; while we were told this was not our role. She still takes them. We never have. When I attended the boys' events and activities that she happened to also attend she would nudge her husband and say, loud enough for me to hear or read her lips, "There's K.E. Laine." She would then turn and stare at me—on and off—throughout the entire event. This occurred at the first and every event thereafter. It was unsettling. I couldn't tell whether she was surprised I was there or believed I shouldn't be, but her behavior made me feel as though my presence was somehow wrong. She would make snide comments and label their family as the one and only, "THE Family." She would perpetuate the message that when Mom is not available, you need *me,* Grandma, not their own father. The boys learned who held authority and who did not, not through conflict, but through repetition and routine. Their grandmother's voice weaved itself into the fabric of alienation. Soft words spoken with

authority, small stories retold until they sounded like truth. Her approval may have felt like a prize they needed to earn by rejecting our family, her affection wrapped in conditions. With a gentle shake of the head or a sigh heavy with judgment, loving us, loving our family, felt like betrayal. A grandparent's wisdom carries weight, her influence quietly tipped the scales, binding the boys in loyalty and reshaping memories themselves.

One of the other traits we started to notice was the storytelling that our oldest at the time had started. White lies began to weave themselves into his childhood, small at first, then growing into elaborate stories about events that never happened. I remember the year he told his third-grade teacher that we celebrated Hanukkah, complete with detailed descriptions of our family traditions. For the record, both my husband and I were raised in Christian homes. Stories like that followed him for years, accounts of amusement parks he had supposedly visited with his mom, pets they never owned, memories that existed only in his mind. When my husband gently brought it up to his ex-wife, she turned it back on him, accusing him of calling *her* kids liars. That was not it at all. Our concern was not about honesty for its own sake but about why he felt the need to invent these stories. The fabrications became so frequent that we found ourselves asking regularly, "Is this a story, or is this real?" It did not stop in childhood, either. The habit continued into his teenage years, a thread running through his life that we could never fully untangle. These fabrications were not just harmless childhood imaginings; they were a symptom of something deeper. Slowly, they revealed the ways his loyalty had been divided, how the influence of alienation had seeped into his sense of truth, leaving him unsure what belonged to him and what belonged to the story someone else had written.

We lived in that perpetual loop of control, conflict, and lies for two years before I became pregnant with our first child together. Despite everything, we were excited. The boys were almost four and eight when their baby brother was born, and for a brief

moment, it seemed like everyone was happy for us. She even bought me a gift from the boys, a stuffed animal she said they had picked out. When the day finally came, and I was in the hospital holding our newborn, the reality of our situation came crashing back. We had to practically beg her to allow the boys just one hour to come with their grandma (my husband's mother) to meet their baby brother. One hour, was all we were granted to share this once-in-a-lifetime moment as a family. I will never forget the story that happened in the elevator on the way up to my hospital room. My mother-in-law, proud and excited, struck up a conversation with a stranger, telling her that the boys were on their way to meet their new brother. Without hesitation, my youngest stepson corrected her, "He's not our brother. He's our HALF brother." My mother in law was stunned and caught off guard. We had never used the term half-brother. Before anyone could respond, the stranger knelt down, looked right at him, and said gently, "There are only full brothers. You enjoy meeting your brother."

We did not realize the weight of that moment. Looking back now, it was the first sign of what was to come, the slow turning of our children against each other, the planting of seeds that our son was not really their true brother. It was the beginning of an emotional unraveling, a quiet, steady effort to make it seem as though our child somehow mattered more to us than hers. The lines were already being drawn.

With a baby at home, life became even busier as she still tried to sign the boys up for anything and everything she could. We finally had to set a boundary. One activity per season. It was not just about time; it was also about money. We were not being unreasonable; we had daycare costs, household bills, and multiple children to provide for. Like most families, we lived on a budget, but in her eyes, our situation did not matter. Somehow, having a child together was painted as a disadvantage to the boys, as if we were ruining their lives because of his/our child. We tried to explain again and again through countless emails. By that point, we had a whole review team for every message we sent. Both sets

of parents, my sister, and close friends would read draft after draft before we sent **anything,** making sure our words were rational and objective. I truly believed that if we communicated calmly, clearly, and fairly, she would have to understand, but it never mattered. No matter how many people helped us word things carefully, no matter how much we tried to compromise, we were always wrong. She could not accept that we lived under a budget and had reasonable boundaries for all of our children.

I say we, but in her mind, it was never us. She saw everything as him, the combative ex-husband who pushed back on everything she wanted for her kids, the kids she loved to "the moon and back." Nothing was seen as a joint decision between my husband and me, and nothing was negotiable.

We even tried to make it simple; if she wanted them in additional activities beyond our one per season boundary, she was welcome to pay for it herself. After all, neither of them paid child support in their divorce decree, they only split certain costs. Still, she refused, because it was not really about the activities; it was about money that she believed she was owed. If my husband did not pay for everything she wanted, then she was not going to spend a dime. In the end, it worked to her advantage because she could frame him as the reason the boys were not allowed to do more, because their dad would not pay for it. It is clear now that the fight over money and activities was never really about the activity itself; it was about creating situations where no matter what we did, we were wrong. Every time we set a limit, she framed it as if we were denying the boys opportunities or being selfish. She made it seem like having a new baby in our family somehow hurt the boys, as though our love and attention were finite and her children were losing out.

The truth is, the boys were not being deprived of anything unreasonable. We were trying to balance schedules, budgets, and family time, but the narrative she pushed intentionally started to seep into the kids' minds. The rules and boundaries we set in our household were twisted into evidence that their dad did not care

enough, that he made life harder, and that he was keeping them from having fun.

That is exactly how the wedge begins to form. When one parent uses financial leverage or activity control to frame the other as uncaring or unfair, the children are put in the impossible position of choosing sides. They began to internalize that story, that one parent was somehow standing in the way of their happiness. It was not just exhausting for us; it was heartbreaking to watch their trust and loyalty so clearly shift. They started telling their mom false stories, but we did not understand why they would lie. When we gently tried to call them out or ask for honesty, it backfired. She would turn it around, blaming my husband and scolding him. It left us confused and frustrated, caught between wanting to teach our kids accountability and watching the other parent undermine that effort. Slowly, we realized that these were not just innocent fibs; they were being shaped and reinforced by her, driving a wedge between our children and us and beginning the slow rewriting of their own memories and understanding of our family and our experiences. It was the shaping of a loyalty conflict.

On the Outside Looking In: Creating Loyalty

Badmouthing and blame: Speaks negatively about the other parent in front of the child. Implies or directly states the other parent is unsafe, selfish, or uncaring. Uses adult conflicts to justify the child's rejection.

Gatekeeping and control: Controls communication or access. Monitors or limits messages, phone calls, or texts. Uses forgotten schedules or last-minute excuses to disrupt visitation.

Emotional manipulation: Makes the child feel guilty for showing love or enjoyment with the other parent. Rewards loyalty and punishes connection with the targeted parent. Acts sad, sick, or anxious when the child spends time with the other parent.

Rewriting history: Distorts past events to paint the other parent as unreliable or cruel. Retells stories with subtle edits that change meaning or blame. Encourages the child to reinterpret normal parenting as mistreatment.

Role reversal: Treats the child as a confidant or emotional partner. Says things like "You're the only one who understands me." Puts the child in a position to choose sides.

Undermining the other parent's authority: Tells the child they do not have to follow the other parent's rules. Contradicts discipline or household expectations. Frames the other parent's boundaries as harsh or unreasonable.

Creating distance and division: Excludes the other parent from school updates, medical information, or decisions. Encourages the child to keep secrets or withhold information. Pushes the child to reject the targeted parent's family or traditions.

False narratives and projection: Accuses the other parent of behaviors they themselves are engaging in. Uses exaggerated emotional language without evidence. Position themselves as the only trustworthy or loving parent.

In essence: The alienating parent's goal, conscious or not, is control. Control over the story, the child's emotions, and ultimately the bond the child has with the other parent. Their tactics often disguise themselves as love, but their result is separation, confusion, and harm.

Chapter 5
The Mirror of Jealousy

Wrapped in all of the other experiences was the ugly face of jealousy. It began with small echoes, ones that almost seemed harmless. We joined a pool one summer, its water slides bright with laughter. We filmed the boys racing down waterslides for the first time, faces alive with joy and sent the proud video at the boys request. Her response was delight for them, but a whispered competition. "That looks like so much fun. I'm so jealous you have a pool like that." Soon after, she and her family joined a water park, rich with water slides far beyond our pool.

That became the rhythm.

We went on a beach vacation; her family followed with their own trip to the same shore.

We went camping with my husband's family, who had a camper; she booked a camping trip of her own. My family's lake house became the boys' haven; several years later, her family bought one, too. According to the boys, their Grandma declared, "We have to buy a lake house, how else will the kids learn water sports?" as if the years of learning with us had never existed. It was petty from the outside, but to us, it was the quiet drumbeat of competition, always needing to prove her family "THE family" was the center, and erasing the memories of what came before with us.

Then came Italy.

The boys were young and impulsive. We worried about the risk of such a big trip at that age with just her and the boys in a foreign country. To take minors out of the country in a divorce, there has to be consent from both custodial parents. My husband expressed his safety concerns and recommended postponing the trip for a few years due to their age. He explained that he wasn't saying no or challenging her ability to care for the boys, and it was nothing personal; it was more about the logistics. In a few years, the boys would be easier to manage, and they would appreciate Italy and all it has to offer more.

Ultimately, she went anyway. Her parents agreed to go with them, which was supposed to make us feel more comfortable with

the trip. However, eventually the truth came out, as it always does, and it revealed yet another subtle manipulation. If we did not allow the trip to happen, then the blame would be placed solely on my husband and his supposed bullying. Now he was not only ruining the experience for their children, but he was also depriving the boys' aging grandparents of the experience, too.

Then, mirroring one of our exact concerns about the trip, we received the call every parent dreads: she had lost our eight year old son, who stepped off a train alone while the family remained on board. Forty-five minutes later, a stranger had helped him to the police station. Had it been reversed, she would have dragged us to court. Instead, we were told to brush it off, that everything was fine.

Italy marked a turning point. No longer was it just mirroring our vacations; it became an escalation. Trips grew grander: Honeymoon resorts, elaborate ski trips, cruises, and Europe's capitals. The world itself became her stage. Yet, we were not jealous. We saw it for what it was: loneliness wrapped in spectacle. She had no partner to share these journeys, so she used the boys as pseudo husbands, pouring money into memories designed to bind their loyalty, and their memories.

Still, she accused us of indifference, throwing in my husband's face details from trips I took with him as a couple, trying to frame every vacation we ever took as something we "left the boys out of." "You called them from a hot tub when they weren't with you on vacation," she said, ignoring the fact that they had just returned from the Bahamas with her, or that she had called them plenty of times when she traveled with friends and shared every detail of her fun. As much as she didn't want them on vacation with us, she wanted them to feel that we didn't want them with us.

This was no longer about vacations. It was about belonging. She framed our family as less, our time as second-rate, our love as conditional. She made them feel that their loyalty had to be chosen, guarded, and performed. When they were on vacation with our

family, she would always call midweek. The calls were not to ask how the trip was going or what the boys were enjoying. Instead, she would tell them about the next trip she was planning with them once they returned, or about what they were missing back at home. Every vacation was interrupted by her need to stay in the forefront of their minds and her steady reminder that their mom was home, missing them and planning for a better vacation when they returned.

By this time, our youngest stepson began showing separation anxiety. We understood it was not a simple attachment. It was conditioning. He wasn't just afraid to leave his mom; he was afraid to betray her. Counselors told us, "He's being placed in the role of man of the house." At only seven, he carried the weight of her loneliness, her need. Her words, "I miss you so much when you're gone," were chains disguised as love. This wasn't healthy bonding; it was a loyalty test. And once planted, it grew deep roots.

She had photos of her marriage to my husband and family pictures that once adorned their mantle when they were married still hung, but in the boys' bedrooms. She dusted off their wedding album to show them many times throughout their childhood, repeating the lines, "Look how in love we were. I don't know why your dad is so angry now." All reminders that their father had destroyed something precious, all designed to paint him as the villain. All of it was done to rewrite the story and make sure their loyalty stayed with her.

The greatest threat to her hold on the boys came when I became pregnant with our second child. From that moment, the campaign to cast our children as outsiders and enemies intensified. Her threats escalated into real action, showing she was willing to take steps to assert control legally.

On the Outside Looking In: Creating Narratives

Excessive competition: one parent always one-ups the other's vacations, gifts, or experiences.

What you can do: Remind your kids that love is not measured in money or miles. Create consistent traditions at your home that do not rely on comparison. Rituals that anchor them in stability, like family game night, Sunday pancakes, or bedtime reading.

Guilt-laden phrases: comments like "I'm so jealous you did that" or "I miss you too much when you're gone," which make children feel selfish for enjoying time with you.

What you can do: Counter quietly, without putting down the other parent. Say, "It's okay to have fun at both homes. You're allowed to love both." Give them permission to enjoy their full childhood.

Parentification: children filling adult roles, being told they are the man of the house or responsible for a parent's happiness.

What you can do: Release them from that weight. Tell them often, "It's not your job to take care of me. It's my job to take care of you." Make your home a place where they get to just be kids.

Gatekeeping: refusing to allow extra time with the other parent, even when reasonable, substituting grandparents or extended family instead.

What you can do: Stick to the parenting plan. Document when deviations happen, but in front of the children, stay steady and calm. They need to see one parent who values structure without drama.

Rewriting history: alienating parents often rewrite the past to create guilt or shift blame, claiming the other parent caused the divorce, made poor parenting choices, or wasn't present during important moments.

What you can do: Respond calmly and truthfully using short, age-appropriate explanations. Focus on facts without defending or attacking. For example, "Dad didn't leave you; he left the marriage. That's very different." Keep your message simple and consistent. Over time, truth repeated with warmth helps your child rebuild trust in their own understanding of the past.

Real family language: phrases like "our family" versus "his family" that split a child's identity in two.

What you can do: Emphasize belonging. "You're part of all your families, and you're loved in both places." Celebrate your child's whole identity.

Emotional anchoring: emotionally inserting themselves into the child's time away, reminding them where their loyalty should lie, and preventing full bonding with the other parent.

What you can do: Set gentle but firm boundaries by agreeing on limited call times, then reassure the children afterward: "It's okay that your mom misses you. We can enjoy our time, too." This preserves connection without letting guilt or manipulation take root.

Chapter 6
False Claims and False Realities

We were overjoyed when we learned our second son was on the way. During a family vacation, we shared the news at a small gender reveal party, and the boys' excitement was contagious. They couldn't wait to tell their mom. Later that week, when they called her with smiles and voices full of joy, her response was cold and dismissive: "Well, I'm sure your stepmom is excited." From that moment on, I began calling our son the caveat. To her, his very existence shifted the balance in a game only she was playing. Our new baby wasn't a blessing; he was a threat.

The shift came quickly. After just one night spent with their mom, the boys returned to us confused. Their joy had faded, replaced by words that weren't their own. "Mom said he isn't our real brother, he's just our half-brother." Our oldest added, "Grandma said since I'm twelve, I'll never be close to him. He's more like a cousin than a brother." The excitement we had shared just days before was gone, stolen in less than twenty-four hours.

When it came time for my scheduled C-section, we asked well in advance for the boys to spend part of the day meeting their new baby brother at the hospital, but we were told they already had plans with "THE Family." They didn't meet their brother until nearly a week after his birth. Even after the baby arrived, the attacks didn't stop. Medical bills became a new battleground, her share disputed endlessly, as though the baby's very existence was a financial slight against her. We would meet our deductible faster, and she would have to start paying half of the medical bills sooner, which was how their shared parenting plan worked at the time. We could feel something brewing beneath the surface, but we had no idea how severe it would become.

Eight months later, it all came crashing down. We returned home from a family event to find a slip from the post office, and when I went to pick up the mail, I opened an envelope that made my hands shake. Inside were thirty-seven separate accusations, each one outrageous, fabricated, and cruel. She had finally done what she had long threatened. She was suing us for custody and child support and trying to tarnish my husband's name and

livelihood. What began as joy in welcoming a new child had been twisted into a weapon. With the arrival of those papers, the battle entered an entirely new stage.

At that time, my family was still grieving, reeling from the loss of my father-in-law, who had fought a brief but fierce battle with pancreatic cancer. Barely three weeks after his passing, those papers arrived. She later told my husband, almost with pride, "I waited a week to file after hearing about your dad," presenting the delay as if it were mercy. In reality, it revealed her timing. While my husband was sick with grief, she chose that moment to strike. Years later, she shared something else that clarified her thinking even further. She told me she was angry that my husband had not invited her to attend his own father's funeral. She felt entitled to be there, and that it was wrong of him not to personally invite her. A woman who had spent years disparaging him still believed she deserved a place in his most private moment of loss. In the wake of his father's death, she was not grieving, she was positioning. At the very moment my husband needed his children the most, she was maneuvering to sever him from their lives, attempting to erase him from the world of his sons, who were only twelve and nine years old.

On the Outside Looking In: Erasing Bonds

Diminishing Bonds: using terms like "half-sibling" or "not a real sibling" to make the older children feel less connected.

What you can do: Strengthen real connections through shared activities, photos, and stories that affirm all siblings belong to one another. Use inclusive language consistently: "your brother," "your sister," "our kids," rather than labels that divide.

Predicting Distance: suggesting the siblings won't be close, planting doubt before a relationship can form.

What you can do: Create positive, low-pressure moments between siblings so they can form their own natural relationship. Remind them that closeness grows from time and experience, not from someone else's predictions.

Withholding Access: controlling when or if children meet the new sibling, often turning moments of joy into moments of loss.

What you can do: Keep access predictable and steady with simple routines (short visits, calls, shared meals, or playtime). Maintain consistency so the bond can grow gradually, even if circumstances are challenging.

Shifting Blame: using financial, medical, or household responsibilities around the baby as points of conflict, framing the new child as a burden.

What you can do: Reframe challenges as family responsibilities, not something caused by the baby or by a targeted parent. Model teamwork and fairness, showing that problem-solving is communal and not rooted in fault.

Division of Love: suggesting the targeted parent prioritizes the baby over them and loves the new child more.

What you can do: Offer consistent reassurance that love expands rather than divides. Highlight moments of equal support and affection, reinforcing that each child holds a unique and secure place in the family.

Court

After hiring our attorney and learning how to combat what we were up against, we spent two solid months compiling evidence to refute her claims. I am beyond grateful that we saved every email, every text message, and even recorded phone conversations. Those details became lifelines in navigating this storm. Not only were we able to refute each of her thirty-seven claims, but we did so with an overwhelming amount of proof: receipts, timelines, and carefully documented records and facts that couldn't be argued. We had everything so meticulously organized digitally and in a thick binder that our law firm joked we should become paralegals. We didn't just defend ourselves, we proved beyond doubt that we were not the parents she painted us to be.

Instead of her plan to take full custody, we were assigned a guardian ad litem, and the process of rewriting their shared parenting plan began. These were the attorneys' opinions of what would be best. This became the hardest season for me as a stepparent. I was completely involved in the case, yet always one step removed. I couldn't attend meetings, share my perspective, or tell the stories I had lived through. When I did sit with our attorney alongside my husband, I felt the weight of needing to stay composed, careful not to be perceived as the emotional wife or stepparent.

There was even a year during that court case when I had to step back from attending the boys' events so I could focus on my own boundaries for my mental well-being. She would never let us be, and my anger ran deep. I was hurt, frustrated, and disgusted by her, but for the boys' sake, I stayed away. I knew that if I confronted her, she would leverage it to paint me as the irrational stepmom, unworthy of time with them.

Up to that point, it was the most stressful and soul-draining experience of my life, and it exposed something deeply broken in our family court system. Parents can file wild, unfounded claims, turning the courtroom into a theater for their own narratives. That

is exactly what she did, spinning her version of reality, while we were left to pick up the pieces, both in our hearts and in our pockets.

The days my husband spent in meetings with the guardian were long and grueling. Rather than treating them as professional discussions, his ex-wife used them as a personal confessional and an opportunity to vent her frustration over not having complete control over the boys. My husband would share the breakdown of these sessions, and I would listen to the accounts afterward, so I could be present when the law would not allow it. What I heard was not merely wrong; it was drenched in her emotions, untethered from truth. Every word was a reflection of her interpretations, her twisting of reality, her sickly vision of what she fabricated our family to look like.

The phrase "You treat *your* kids better than *my* kids" echoed so often that the guardian ad litem finally spoke up: "They are BOTH of YOUR kids."

Now, looking back, I see it all clearly. Everything she accused my husband of was textbook parental alienation, down to the phrasing, the manipulation, the erasure of their bond. My only lingering question is why the guardian did not see it. I cannot say what could have been done differently, but had we known the term parental alienation then, we might have had strategies to shield our boys from the slow, insidious brainwashing that was happening right before our eyes.

She managed to drag the case out for nearly three years. It was emotionally, mentally, and financially exhausting. In the end, we pushed for what had been missing in the original shared parenting plan: equity. We were granted a 50/50 custody schedule, a fairer division of medical expenses, and written protections that safeguarded our time. For example, she was no longer allowed to schedule vacations over Father's Day or my husband's birthday, which was a habit she had used year after year to weaken Dad's role.

As draining as the process was, we were relieved with the

outcome. We won the battle and walked away with more than the previous shared parenting plan had given. The shared parenting plan finally felt balanced, and we believed it would allow for healthier co-parenting. Whether she regretted filing the case or not, we will never know. What we do know is that there was a shift, and her tactics evolved. They became less about legal battles and more about psychological control. She began positioning herself as the boys' friend rather than their parent, blurring boundaries and fostering secrecy. This shift would prove to be another fork in the road, leading their emotions down a slippery slope.

On the Outside Looking In: Protect Yourself

Save every email, text, and message exchange: our state is a one-party consent state, so if my husband was involved in a conversation with his ex, it was recorded and legal. This is not the case in every state.

Keep a running log of dates, times, and conversations: as a stepparent, I helped my husband by listening to calls on speaker and taking notes so he could have the takeaways while I documented important details. He stopped casual conversations so we could have documentation of every event.

Organize your records digitally and in hard copy: consistent organization becomes crucial over time.

Avoid emotional responses, stick to facts: practice the grey rock method, using short, bland answers and avoiding emotional reactions. Grey Rock is A communication strategy where you make yourself emotionally uninteresting, neutral, and unresponsive so a high-conflict or manipulative person loses motivation to provoke or engage with you.

Court Appointed Communication Apps: look into apps that can be used directly with the court system if needed. Such as Our Family Wizard or Talking Parents.

Remember: documentation isn't just proof, it is protection.

Chapter 7
Silent Manipulation

After the court case, the ruling was clear: both parents were to act in the boys' best interest. At least, that is what the rewritten shared parenting plan said on paper. However, she continued to frame her protests as the children's voices: "They're too afraid to ask you themselves. They want to be here, with me, at my house." Those weren't their words; they were hers, handed down like scripts. The truth was, the boys enjoyed their time with us. Ask any friend, any family member; they thrived in our home, in the laughter of their brothers, in the simple rituals of dinners, games, and weekends together. In the consistency that our home provided.

Even though the shared parenting plan gave us equal footing, another shift began, one quieter and more dangerous. As our oldest stepped into high school, parenting on her side faded, replaced by something more enticing: friendship. Rules softened, confidences deepened, and secrets grew. It was not parenting, it was alliance, and it was invisible to us at first, hidden beneath the veil of adolescence and cloaked in the language of trust.

We thought the hardest battles were behind us when the new shared parenting plan was signed. We didn't yet know that this loss of control in court would only fuel her to find a subtler weapon, not bound by legal papers, but etched into the boys' hearts. There was a desperate need to prove to the boys that she loved them more, and an even deeper desire for their love to belong only to her.

Upon her request, the new shared parenting plan carried a stipulation: weekly updates. We were to account for the days the boys spent with us, a ledger of ordinary life and what they did, where they went, how they lived under our roof. She saw them every day before school on the weeks the boys were with us because that is where they would stop to get their rides to school since her house was positioned in their school zone, yet she demanded more. So we wrote. Carefully. Diligently. As though our words might build a bridge or at least hold open the door to honest communication.

Once again, the bridge did not stretch both ways. Her updates to us became thin, vague, and almost empty. No insights, no details, only silence dressed in formality. Her reasoning was always the same: "The boys are old enough to share those details themselves." Any parent of teenagers knows the truth: adolescence is not a season of abundant conversations. Instead, we were left trying to piece together a life we could not see, fumbling in the dark, navigating waters without a compass.

Meanwhile, we provided detailed chronicles of games played, meals shared, small victories, and quiet evenings, just as she had requested. Over time, we realized that the updates we provided became something else in her hands. Rather than building bridges, she used the updates to fuel the fire she had created. We had hoped for openness. What we received was silence. And in that silence, her control grew because we had no account of how the boys were living during the weeks they spent with her.

Once they each received a cell phone, she never truly let them go. Her words would ring through constantly on our weeks and our vacations alike:

"I love you so much, I hope you know that."

"I miss you."

"I wish I could do those things with you."

"Guess what you are missing while you are with your dad."

Over and over, the messages dripped through the hours like a steady reminder of where their loyalty belonged. Even when she had seen them that morning and afternoon on their brief stops home before returning to our house, she would text. She involved them in decisions about weekends with her or upcoming family trips far in advance, all through text messages, even when there was no need for immediate input and could wait until her shared parenting time would begin.

She kept the texts coming, not to connect, but to stay present. To remind them who was waiting for them, and to make our home feel unimportant and temporary. It was affection used as a tether, soft, constant, and quietly suffocating. It turned our time against us

and replaced their happy moments with guilt and worry, something that as children, they couldn't fully define.

Our youngest son still struggles, even to this day, with the joy he feels when he is with us. Anytime we do something together as a family, or anything that is supposed to be fun, a look comes over his face, like a flicker of guilt, as if he has just remembered he is enjoying himself without his mom. Almost without fail, he will bring up something he did with her or her family, as if being present with us is somehow wrong. He can't fully relax. He can't fully enjoy the time. Just existing with us feels off-limits.

It is the quiet work of parental alienation. It is the shaping of a child's allegiance so subtly that even happiness brings guilt, and love becomes something they can't fully give or receive at one home.

The very things we knew were best for children, like consistent boundaries, gentle correction, and lessons woven into mistakes, were recast as something darker. What we called guidance, she called control. What we meant as love, she projected as harm. For example, when our oldest dreamed of competing in an Ironman, we encouraged him to take ownership of that goal. We asked him to research what it would take to participate in the event, including the training, the costs, and the commitment. We also suggested that he look into local triathlon clubs before making big purchases or quitting his high school sports teams, which he said he was going to do. We saw it as teaching responsibility and follow-through; she saw it as withholding support.

There was constant undermining wrapped in sympathy, and neither boy learned what actual parenting looked like.

"I'm so sorry about the rules at your dad's house."

"I can't do anything about the rules at your dad's, and I am sorry."

"Don't tell him about this, and I won't either."

"Your dad is so angry. I'm sorry you have to go through that."

"I'll talk to him so you don't have to deal with it."

Each phrase seemed small on its own, but together they

worked like water dripping on stone, eroding trust and reshaping truth. *Angry* became the defining word attached to my husband, despite the fact that it never described who he was or how our home functioned. Friends and family would never choose this as a descriptor for my husband. It was a convenient label she used to turn our parenting negative. It was was simple, repeatable, and misleading. Over time, she stopped using the word to try and explain moments and started using it to rewrite the reality our home.

We tried to keep the lines of communication open. When the boys stumbled, when they needed guidance, we shared. We wrote down our conversations, believing that parenting was a partnership, even in two homes. Yet what came back to us was silence or a thin reply: "I had a high-level conversation with them." No details. No exchange. Just a wall of vagueness.

Any challenge they faced in life, she would either bulldoze or make excuses for. If they did poorly on a school assignment, it was the teacher's faultIf we held them accountable for something we had asked them to do, we became the "unfair" parents. In time, even ordinary lessons in responsibility, follow-through and respect, were reframed as something harmful, rather than what they were: the normal work of raising children. What should have been a united effort to raise children became a slow dismantling of everything we had tried to build. It was as if our understanding of adolescence, built from years in education, was a threat to her, something she needed to undo, as though we knew nothing about children at all.

On the Outside Looking In: Hidden Tactics

The "Fun Parent" Persona: recasting themselves as the fun parent or friend, undermining the other parent's authority.

What you can do: Stay consistent with expectations and routines so your home remains predictable and safe. Reinforce that fun is allowed, but so are boundaries, responsibility, and respect. Create meaningful, enjoyable moments that build true connection rather than competition.

Secrets Create Sides: encouraging secrecy ("don't tell" or "I won't tell your dad/mom") to develop hidden alliances.

What you can do: Make your home a place where honesty is safe by responding calmly when a child shares information. Remind them gently that secrets between parents and children are unhealthy and unnecessary. Praise openness so they associate truth with comfort, not fear.

Guilt by Affection: redefining rules so the child feels guilty for enjoying time with the other parent.

What you can do: Reassure the child that loving both parents is healthy, normal, and encouraged. Celebrate their positive experiences with the other household instead of competing with them. Help them understand that affection is not betrayal.

Subtle Manipulation: using quiet psychological tactics instead of overt legal ones, making alienation harder to detect and prove.

What you can do: Document patterns calmly and consistently, even small ones, in case they become significant later. Trust your intuition while staying grounded in facts and observable behavior. Seek professional support (therapy, parenting coordinators, or legal guidance) when manipulation escalates.

Emotional Tethering: keeping the child emotionally tied through constant contact, affection, or reminders, preventing full connection with the other parent.

What you can do: Set reasonable boundaries around communication during your parenting time. Encourage the child to be fully present in each home without guilt. Provide a warm, stable environment where they feel emotionally anchored.

Undermined Authority: teaching the child that one home is safe and the other is not, distorting trust and security.

What you can do: Reinforce safety and stability through consistent routines, calm responses, and predictable caregiving. Avoid defending yourself through anger. Instead, let your actions and environment speak for you. Focus on rebuilding trust through steady presence, empathy, and reliability.

Chapter 8
The Quiet Divide

The four years our oldest spent in high school marked the beginning of a quiet unraveling. At first, we told ourselves it was normal teenage resistance, the push and pull that comes with growing up. Since we both teach middle school, we know adolescence well, its turbulence and its beauty, but this felt different. What we didn't realize then was that our parenting was being twisted and used against us. The very lessons meant to guide our kids like keeping track of assignments, managing allowance, setting goals, respecting boundaries, apologizing when wrong, and taking responsibility for their actions, were recast as cruelty. Our efforts to teach structure and accountability were painted as control and anger.

Our expectations were simple, but when one parent undermines the other, the cloth begins to unravel. Our morals, our values, our priorities were all diminished, all reframed as oppression. We encouraged the boys to be their own people, to explore their interests and build their friendships. When they stumbled, as all children do, we took the time to help them see the lesson in the fall. After all, life is not built on perfection but on the courage to fall, learn, and begin again.

However, lessons cannot take root when a child is taught to resent the very act of being parented. It is hard when the two homes are vastly different. One focuses on blurring the lines between parenting and friendship, and the other home is built on parenting with guidance and ownership. Their mother deliberately stopped being the parent and became their friend who "understood." She reframed herself as a friend who promised safety from a home she called harsh. The message was simple: staying with her was better, easier, and right. "THE Family" was the only family who truly loved them.

We didn't yet understand how subtle and powerful that shift truly was and how quietly truth can be rewritten when love is weaponized. What began as lessons in responsibility became evidence of oppression. What began as parenting became, in their eyes, proof that we were the problem, the tyrants, the villains. With

each passing year, the distance deepened. Animosity took root, and resentment began to show its face.

Once, I reached out to their mother, asking if she had noticed our oldest's growing anger. I wondered if she saw the same and hoped we could work together to navigate teenage trials and tribulations. Her response was simple: "I don't think there's anything wrong. He's just been rude lately, and I even had my dad and brother talk to him about it."

She hid the truth because the truth was of her own making. She was cultivating the anger and resentment that we mistook for typical teenage behavior. Unknowingly, I played right into her hand. So, we continued to chalk it up to adolescence.

It wasn't always bad. There were still many good moments during those high school years; family game nights, movie nights, shared meals, long car rides, outings, cheering at sporting events, celebrating first marathons, school events, birthdays and holidays, high school dances, first romances, and the quiet, everyday moments that made us a family. We celebrated achievements, glowed with pride, and basked in those fleeting moments when we felt whole, a family of six, bound by love, unaware of the storm slowly taking shape.

Communication started to fade, little by little, over those four years. Subtle at first, then unmistakable. We didn't know for awhile but found out that she had begun letting our oldest stay home alone at her house while she traveled for work when he was heading into his Junior year of high school instead of having him come to our house, where dinner would be waiting, and people who cared about him would be around. She said he didn't want to come, but by then she had already begun teaching him that staying alone was "college preparation." In truth, it was another layer in the quiet campaign to paint our home as unwanted, to make him believe that solitude was safer than being with his dad or where his "half-brothers" would disturb him.

Then she started letting our younger son stay home too even though he was only in eighth grade with his older brother which

only led to more bouts of anxiety that he had possessed since elementary school, creating a gradual and subtle divide of his commitment to our family. He began spending more time in his room to remove himself from the brothers he once couldn't get enough of and distance himself from being an active participant in our family life. The very brothers he loved, adored, and was best friends with started becoming a burden.

However, we continued to be flexible, letting them stay at their mom's when they had events that made it easier to be closer to school. At the time, it felt like the reasonable thing to do, proof that we were trying to work with them, to show we cared about their schedules and comfort. Looking back, I believe every time we agreed without making up the time, it quietly reinforced a story she was already spinning. The message became that we didn't care about them, when in truth, we thought we were doing exactly the opposite.

What we saw as cooperation was used as manipulation. Each small compromise chipped away at our connection. It wasn't one big event that changed everything; it was a slow erosion, almost imperceptible at first. The distance didn't just grow between homes; it grew between hearts, and we were being written out of a story we were still trying to be part of.

On the Outside Looking In: The Signs We Missed

Growing disrespect: subtle eye rolls, sarcastic tone, dismissal of anything we said as overreaction or control.

Emotional distance: quietness that replaced laughter, a hesitance to share details about their lives, as if conversation itself had become dangerous.

Shifting loyalties: one parent became the "safe" one, the fun one, the friend, while we were cast as the problem to be escaped.

Rewritten history: memories that were built together are reinterpreted, stripped of joy, and retold through a darker lens.

Secrecy: the sense that conversations were being repeated elsewhere and twisted into something unrecognizable.

Guilt: the feeling that no matter how patient, how kind, or how consistent we were, it was never enough to compete with the narrative being fed to them.

Isolation: not just theirs, but ours. The slow silencing of a relationship that had once been full of life.

We didn't see it then for what it was. We thought we were navigating adolescence. We thought we were giving them space to grow. In truth, we were losing them to a story someone else was writing, a story that painted love as control, guidance as punishment, and distance as freedom.

Chapter 9
The Weekend That Changed Everything

Senior year began like any other school year. Busy schedules, cross-country meets to attend, soccer games to watch, and the everyday hustle of our lives as teachers. We helped our oldest navigate his first real heartbreak, offering advice and steady reassurance when he felt low. We shopped for a new suit for senior-year events and homecoming, and I had just finished helping him edit a college essay, guiding him toward the next chapter of his life. His eighteenth birthday came and went, which was quietly marked in ways we didn't yet understand. Only later did it become clear that this milestone had been framed for him as something else entirely. Is was not just a birthday, but a kind of freedom. An escape. A moment he had been taught to wait for and to use, as a "right" that justified no longer needing us at all.

Thanksgiving followed. Our ten-year-old wanted to run a 5K with his big brother, and the weekend unfolded with laughter, teamwork, and the simple comfort of being together. On the Sunday before school resumed, the boys and their dad sat at the kitchen table playing euchre with teasing and, giggling, the ordinary moments that turn a house into a home. The next day, they returned to their mother's for the week. We didn't know it then, but that Thanksgiving weekend would be the last time we would see our oldest son for almost a year. The following week, he sent a message to my husband. He was going to stay at his mom's for the foreseeable future, citing "differences in his and his dad's relationship." He reminded us that he was eighteen now and that we could no longer tell him what to do. We were confused. Shocked. Stunned. We reached out to him, only to be met with silence. We reached out to his mom, and she repeated the same message: he was eighteen, and we had no say over how he lived his life.

The week before, he had mentioned wanting to spend a little more time at his mom's because of activities he was involved in, but never once did he suggest he was planning to abandon us. This wasn't a fleeting thought or a teenage whim. This was new. This was deliberate. This was calculated.

We went through all of December without any explanation. We had no texts, no conversation, just emptiness. A void we were left to figure out on our own. He skipped Christmas. He missed birthdays. He was gone.

After the holidays, the severity of the situation began to settle in. He had become involved in a new church that figuratively swept him off his feet. It was a fast and furious devotion and relationship with God and the church community that was not the church we had been affiliated with. We did not have a problem with the church, but we were starting to question anything and everything that could answer what was going on, since we were left without any answers.

Hidden in his empty bed that had not been slept in for almost a month, we found a disturbing annotation in a Bible about hating your father, mother, brother, and sisters in order to be a true disciple. We thought at that moment that this could be the cause for what was happening, so we reached out to his mom with our concerns about what we found. She responded that the church had nothing to do with what was happening and said that she would meet with us in person. However, she warned us that we wouldn't like what she was going to say.

Desperate and unsure of what else to do, we agreed.

We met at a coffee shop. It was there she told us that our oldest had decided to leave because of how cruel our house had been and that it had been going on for years, though we "just didn't want to see it." She also said our younger son was on the same path, that we were going to lose him, too.

Looking back, I regret that meeting. We sat for three hours listening to her recount every supposed wrongdoing, from when the boys were two and four up to the present. I listened to every terrible thing she claimed we had done to *her* kids and heard her repeat over and over how she loved them "to the moon and back."

At one point, I asked my husband to leave the coffee shop and take a walk, hoping that if I was alone, she might relent. Instead, she continued, telling me all the ways he had hurt *her*

children and her over the years, even warning me that he was such an angry person and that I should "watch out."

I said nothing in our defense because all I saw was a woman who had not moved on in fifteen years, someone who held on to the bitterness that caused this to happen in the first place. It was all distorted, false, and wildly shaped by anger, jealousy, and a deep need for revenge.

It was the exact set of accusations she had written into her court case five years prior, and still, I listened. I pretended to befriend her, holding onto a fragile hope that if I let her vent, she would go home and tell our oldest that we just wanted to talk.

For example, she told me that our oldest had been devastated because we "didn't care enough" to throw him a party after his first marathon, but the truth was far different. That morning, my husband had taken him to the marathon at six a.m., and as a family, we followed him to four stops along the route, celebrating each milestone, including the finish line. My sister, our direct neighbor and steadfast ally, had attended two of those stops before heading home to prepare a party for him at her house, just fifty yards from ours, because she wanted to help us, knowing we wouldn't be back in time to get everything ready from being at the marathon all day.

That evening, when the party began, our oldest was radiant with joy. Our whole family was there, laughter spilling over as we shared his excitement and ordered Chinese food at his request.

Yet, in her retelling, she transformed that happiness into hurt. She rewrote the memory entirely: our son's elation became bitterness, our shared celebration became neglect because the celebration was held at my sister's house instead of our own. We didn't "care" about him enough to have the party at *our* house.

I know now that she had not been at his first marathon because she had been away on a work trip and returned the next day. In her telling, she poured her own guilt, her jealousy, and her need for control into that moment, twisting it until it no longer resembled the truth.

The joy he felt, the pride we shared, and the love surrounding him were all stripped away and recast as evidence of our supposed

cruelty.

This, I realize, is the essence of parental alienation: a memory reshaped, a child's experience rewritten, a mother's absence turned into blame. And in that coffee shop, listening to her, I could see the pattern repeat itself, a web of distortion spun from bitterness and envy, stretching across years of our family's life.

So many of the events she described had never happened. She blamed us for failing to meet even the most basic needs of *her* children. All I did was listen, pleading with her, insisting that all we wanted was a relationship and a chance to talk with our oldest son. We left the meeting discouraged and disoriented, our heads spinning from the lies and distortions. Yet we still held a small hope that she might convince our oldest to at least have a conversation with us. What I know now is that she never intended for that to happen. She was manipulating me, trying to turn me against my husband and widen the divide. Even after that meeting, she maintained strict control over how and when my husband was allowed to communicate. She instructed him to text our oldest only once a week, and only with a brief message saying he was thinking of him. We complied, believing that cooperation might reduce conflict and support reconnection. My husband followed her instructions exactly, holding onto the hope that she was reinforcing our efforts privately. After three months of unanswered messages, it became clear this was not about protecting boundaries or reducing stress. It was about restricting access. With that realization and a growing understanding of parental alienation, we stopped following her directives.

A discussion never happened with our oldest, texts went unacknowledged, and the distance only grew as the months dragged on.

We were devastated, hurt, and confused. It consumed countless sleepless nights for me and made the hours of the day feel heavy and empty at times.

This is when we began to research. I poured over articles, books, and the internet, searching for any clue, any sign of what was happening. Two months into this small, cautious search, I stumbled upon something that made my heart stop: PA (Parental

Alienation).

I had found what I had been looking for.

I found *us.*

My mouth literally hit the floor. How had we never known that parental alienation was a term, an action, and something that had been happening to our family?

It is hard to describe the mix of emotions I felt. The satisfaction and devastation all at once. Relief that we finally understood what was happening, but grief at realizing that it isn't something that can be erased, fixed, or explained away by simply telling a child, "You've been manipulated; we are good people."

However, giving it a name changed everything. Seeing that so many other families had experienced the same pain, that we weren't alone, gave us hope, or at least answers to desperate questions we would never have been able to identify on our own.

For the first time, the chaos made sense. Knowing that was both terrifying and strangely empowering. For the first time, we could see the shape of what had been happening to our family. The pain, the distance, the confusion, it was no longer random or inexplicable. It had a name, and with that name came understanding, however painful.

Understanding didn't fix it. Understanding didn't bring him back. But it gave us something we hadn't had before: clarity. With clarity came the first glimmer of hope that maybe, just maybe, we could begin to find a way through the silence, the lies, and the heartbreak.

My husband attended the remainder of my stepson's high school events as a silent presence in the bleachers. He watched as his mother walked him across the field on senior sports night, a lifetime of raising him reduced to something unseen. On other senior nights, he sat in the shadows. At graduation, he waited for over an hour afterward, hoping to find him to take a photo and give him a book we had carried since kindergarten, signed by every teacher along the way. He never came. These were milestones we will never get back. We remained on the sidelines, unacknowledged, watching a lifetime of parenting slip just out of reach. And yet, through it all, my husband never stopped reaching

out. He continued to send messages of love, many of them unanswered, holding onto hope while sitting in silence, heartbroken, but still present.

Eventually, we learned that our oldest had started seeing a counselor. After some thought and research, we decided to draft a handwritten letter to the counselor. We didn't want to interfere with his progress, and we respected the confidentiality between client and therapist, but we wanted the counselor to know that there might be something deeper shaping our son's conversations, something that extended beyond what appeared on the surface.

We didn't know how the counselor would respond, but my husband explained that we had a well-documented case of PA and simply wanted the counselor to have the information in case it could help in any way. His motivation was clear: he loved his son deeply and wanted to do everything possible to support him.

About two months after sending that letter, approximately nine months since he left, our oldest reached out to his dad to ask if he wanted to join him in a counseling session with his counselor. It was good news, the first contact we had had in months, and a chance to finally have a conversation with a third party present.

The outcome of that session was emotional and positive, but it also brought to light some deeply wounded perceptions and beliefs that were not shaped by reality and could not have been his own thinking, despite what he believed.

The saddest perception of all was that he believed my husband loved our kids more than him and his brother. He assumed that because his dad was married to me that he would love our children together more. This validated us even further, as these were the exact phrases his mother had used over and over during the years of the court case.

My husband cleared up misconceptions and felt hopeful after the session. I was happy for him too, relieved that he finally had the chance to talk and, hopefully, begin repairing their relationship.

He is away at college. He answers texts from my husband and my mother-in-law, but only at a surface level. He has not sought out our family, asked about his brothers, or tried to be involved.

In cases of parental alienation, we know we have to play the long game. Healing and reconnection cannot be forced, and he will have to come to his own conclusions over time.

I hope he can slowly rediscover the pieces of his childhood that belong to him: the laughter and chaos of family dinners, game nights, movie nights, trips to the pool, lazy mornings with his baby brothers, visits to parks and museums, the quiet moments that were just ours. These memories, free from manipulation, are the ones that can remind him of love that was always present, even when distorted by someone else's agenda.

I also hope my youngest stepson can remain grounded in reality, not allow anxiety to overtake him, and continue to experience the genuine joy he feels when he is with us: present, safe, and unburdened. I hope he never feels guilt for loving us, or pressure to carry someone else's narrative at the expense of his own lived experience. More than anything, I hope he is allowed to hold onto what is real, and to grow without being asked to question his own happiness.

For children of parental alienation, the work is often slow and internal. They must learn to separate truth from manipulation, reclaim their own experiences, and reconnect with the people who genuinely loved them. It takes time, reflection, and a safe space to remember what was real, and ultimately, it is their journey to rebuild trust, identity, and connection on their own terms.

As for me, this is why I am writing this book. I am wounded. I am hurt. I cannot move forward as easily as my husband can. He has a bond, an unconditional love, for his biological children. As the stepparent, I have always felt unseen. It is hard to fight for something I am not sure I ever truly had. Logically, I know my stepson's are victims. I understand how this happened. Emotionally, though, it is far harder to accept. I willingly married a man with children, ready to accept the responsibility of raising two children that were not mine. I was never met with love or affection, yet I accepted it anyway. I was recently asked, "Do you think she knew what she was actually doing?" I have reflected on that statement and to the best of my ability I believe many of the things she did were intentional. I no longer doubt that. The choices to

withhold, to frame, to interfere, to ask certain questions and avoid others; those were deliberate acts. They required planning. They required repetition. They required a willingness to continue even after the consequences began to surface. Yet still, I want to believe that not everything was done with full awareness. Not because that belief excuses the damage, but because the alternative; that every moment was calculated, feels too neat, and ultimately untrue. Harm often emerges from a combination of choice and chaos, intention and emotion. Some of what happened seems rooted less in strategy and more in insecurity. Less in planning and more in instability. A fear of losing control quietly transformed into a need to control a belief that she was protecting her children from something she ultimately feared herself. Over time, repetition replaced reflection. Actions stopped being examined. I believe there were moments when she continued without fully confronting what those actions were doing. Not because the harm was invisible, but because acknowledging it would have required her to stop. It explains how someone can participate in harm without ever naming it. How a person can know just enough to act, but not enough to stop. This was not innocence. It was avoidance, and avoidance, sustained over time, becomes its own form of responsibility. The boys did not experience these actions as accidental. They experienced them as consistent. Predictable. A pattern woven into the rhythm of daily life. Whether the behavior was driven by fear, insecurity, or a need for control, the outcome remained the same. Love became conditional. Truth became negotiable and loyalty became something to be earned.

I hold both truths now: that much of what happened was intentional, and that some of it likely was not. Holding both does not weaken the story. It strengthens it. It reflects the complexity of our story and the difficult reality that lasting damage does not require clear intent. I want to believe some of it was unintentional, not to lessen responsibility, but to tell the truth as completely as I know how, because healing begins with honesty. This is where my understanding ends, and where the truth, finally, stands on its own. No child should ever be used as a weapon between parents. No parent should ever convince a child to turn away from

someone who is willing, loving, and longing to be part of their life. The harm my stepchildren carry is quiet but immense, and it lives beneath their smiles, shaping their hearts in ways they cannot yet name or understand.

My story, my life has been about endurance. I keep surviving, watching from the outside looking in, and hoping that one day I will no longer feel like an outsider. Yet still, somewhere beyond the miles of hurt and silence, there is a quiet, stubborn hope. A hope that hearts can mend, that truths can be recognized, and that love, patient, persistent, and unwavering, can find its way home. Until then, I keep standing, breathing, and believing that the story is not yet finished.

On the Outside Looking In: Surviving PA

Acknowledge what is happening: Denial only prolongs the pain. Naming it, understanding that the distance, the resentment, and the false narratives are not your fault, is the first step toward clarity. Knowledge is power, and recognizing PA for what it is allows you to separate your love from the lies that have been woven.

Manage your expectations: Your child may not return to you on your timeline. They may reject you, lash out, or remain distant for years. This is not a reflection of your worth or your love; it is the result of manipulation and confusion. Accepting that you cannot control their choices, only your own actions, is critical.

Document and communicate carefully: Keep a record of interactions, maintain boundaries, and consider involving neutral third parties, counselors, therapists, or mediators when possible.

Protect your own heart: Parental alienation can leave you feeling invisible, exhausted, and broken. Seek support from your partner, friends, therapists, or support groups. Protect your mental and emotional health. You cannot pour from an empty cup, and endurance is impossible without care for yourself.

Hold onto love without expectation: This is perhaps the hardest part. Love your child even if they reject you, even if your words are unanswered. Show up with patience, consistency, and integrity. The seeds of connection planted now may not bear fruit for years, but they are still being planted.

Keep hope alive: PA is a long game, but truth has a way of surfacing. Time and perspective often allow children to see the love they were denied and the manipulation they endured. You may not witness the moment, but your faithfulness matters

Chapter 10

What We Carry Forward

We continue to navigate the journey with my younger stepson as he works through anxiety. This is an anxiety shaped in many ways by years of parental alienation. The hardest part is knowing how much of his worldview has been constructed for him by someone else, yet unable to speak that truth directly because he is still too vulnerable, and too tangled in the loyalty binds woven around him. During appointments with counselors and doctors, my husband chooses every word carefully, trying to offer insight without sounding accusatory or unbalanced. It feels like walking a tightrope in the dark, balancing what we know, what we fear, and what he can actually carry. This dynamic has been present since he was three years old. His mother spent years searching for anything, no matter how minor or out of context, to blame on his father. Behavior concerns, emotional swings, school struggles, imagined medical conditions. Every test came back clear and specialists ruled out physical causes. Every path pointed to anxiety, except in the one place where acknowledgment would have mattered most - his mother. She has never acknowledged anxiety may be a cause. Not once.

We have watched and continue to watch him move in and out of counseling, often ending just when sessions begin to reveal something meaningful. Other times he sits in sessions with painful silence because he can't put words to what he feels. Therapy continues only until the truth drifts too close to the surface and she tries to pull him out of counseling, a pattern that has become undeniable over time. Part of me believes she is afraid of what sustained counseling might uncover. Another part believes that keeping him in a perpetual state of struggle ensures he will remain dependent on her. Parental alienation does not always look dramatic. It often hides behind the appearance of parental concern or overprotection. In the process it strips children of essential skills: resilience, accountability, confidence, and the ability to stand on their own.

Both of my stepchildren have been shaped by this. They were not given the space to develop independence or to work through challenges without interference from their mother, despite how much we tried to encourage those skills. The effects are not

loud or immediate. They are slow, subtle, and difficult to witness, like watching a foundation erode one small, almost invisible crack at a time. In our home, we fight that erosion deliberately. We create consistency. We encourage independence. We leave room for questions, mistakes, and growth. Alongside us, whether he realizes it or not, my younger stepson is fighting too, simply by continuing to thrive here. By valuing his relationships with his brothers. By laughing easily. By settling into the sense of safety and steadiness this house offers him. My hope is that he always knows this will be a place he can return without confusion. I hope he does not feel bound to follow in his older brother's footsteps, but instead learns that he is allowed to speak up, to question what he has been told, and to use his own rational thinking to evaluate what he already knows, deep down, to be true. Most of all, I hope he understands that he is allowed to love fully, to have fun freely, and to experience all sides of his family without guilt or hesitation. He is up against a battle he does not yet know he is fighting. His mother continues to rely on lies and distortions, hiding information and telling stories that collapse under scrutiny, while presenting a carefully curated version of events to the outside world. We continue our quiet fight behind closed doors. It is exhausting and offers no clear victories, because the goal has never been to prove her wrong. The goal has always been to protect the boys from the fallout of a narrative built on control, and to give them a truer, steadier ground on which to stand.

Life added a new chapter of its own just before I was getting ready to publish this book. Our oldest reached out. After a year of silence he called his dad and then visited our house. During those conversations we learned things his mother had withheld; information no parent should ever be denied. These were not small omissions. They were serious, painful truths kept from us for reasons that have no excuse. We put our pride aside immediately. The moment he reached out, the door opened. Our home opened. Our hearts opened, even as they carried the weight of past hurts. We wanted him to see, without any doubt, that he still has a place with us. That we never stopped caring. That no distortion or lie can erase the reality of who we are or how we love.

His younger brothers were shy when he arrived. A year apart feels like a lifetime to a child. They hovered with hesitation, curiosity, and hope. Slowly the room softened. A few shared memories surfaced. A few tentative smiles returned. That single visit meant more than he will ever fully understand. For the first time in a long time, it felt possible to rebuild. Not to recreate the family we once were before everything fractured, but to build something new with the pieces we still have. Something steadier and hopefully grounded in honesty instead of manipulation. We carry the hope that foundations can be rebuilt even when the work is slow and uncertain.

Not long after, we had another opportunity to sit with him, this time over lunch while he was home from college during a break. We framed the meeting as an open invitation rather than a confrontation. A chance for him to ask questions and for us to offer clarity wherever we could. Sitting across from him, I saw parental alienation in motion. The familiar messages were there. The same themes and deep disgust his mother has carried toward my husband for years now surfaced through his own words. They sounded like his, but they were not born from his lived experience. We chose our words carefully. We explained without blaming, we listened without dismissing. We shared perspective without telling him he was wrong. It required steady restraint to speak honestly while resisting the urge to defend ourselves fully or tell him he is not remembering the events correctly. The goal was never to win an argument, but to preserve connection, even if understanding had to come later. Still, every question he asked seemed to add another layer to a story that lacked depth or substance. When we gently clarified or asked follow up questions, the narratives collapsed. They could not withstand even light examination because they were not his own independent thinking and were not grounded in reality. Twice he said, "Mom told me." I have reflected on that statement many times since. Why would a parent tell a child what to believe about the other parent? Yet, this is exactly what parental alienation is built on. The rewriting of a child's experiences. The reshaping of memory and the subtle form of psychological conditioning that often hides behind the

appearance of truth telling. Near the end of that conversation, he said something else, something that echoed long after the table was cleared.

"I have no memory of my mom and dad together," he said, "but I think I just never had time to adjust to having a stepmom."

I did not argue with him. I did not defend myself. I believed him. What I understand now is that he was never being asked to adjust to me. He was adjusting to a story told about me. A story shaped by someone else's inability, or refusal, to accept my presence in his life. Adjustment requires more than time. It requires safety. Consistency. Permission to hold more than one truth at once. Time alone is not enough when a child's reality is repeatedly interrupted, reframed, or quietly rewritten. In that light, his sentence was not an accusation. It was a reflection of the environment he was raised in, where loyalty came with conditions and narratives were inherited rather than examined.

He deserves to have a relationship with both parents. He wants to try, but it is recognizable that a part of us exist in his mind as villains, marked and tainted. He seems to believe that our entire existence throughout his childhood was centered on making his life harder. I told him that every decision we made was intended to create the best version of himself, so that when he reached adulthood he would have the tools to thrive. But logic cannot dismantle a narrative reinforced for fifteen years. Each explanation was met with another accusation, as though the story had to keep expanding to survive. His mother has positioned herself as the victim for most of his life, and now he carries that same lens. I left that conversation wishing I had asked him what we did right or what good memories he still holds. That question will have to wait, if he ever allows space for it in the future. We ended the conversation with the door open. We told him he could ask questions anytime and that we are willing to talk and work through whatever he needs. We were also honest. We will not beg or chase him into a relationship. He knows where we are and he knows he belongs in our family. The invitation stands. Time will

tell what comes next. The step forward was small, but the damage runs deep, and his mother continues to deepen the wound every chance she can. Still, it was a step and in families shaped by alienation, even small steps matter

One day I will give him this book. Not today. Right now belongs to healing and quiet presence. This stage is about showing him stability, truth, and love without conditions. Maybe it will be enough. It may not undo the years shaped by alienation but it gives us something to build on, one conversation, one visit, and one fragile step at a time.

If there is any justice for families fractured by manipulation and silence, then I can only hope that the truth will find its way home, piece by piece.

The Quiet Cost

I stayed when love was torn,
when truth was used for blame.
I spoke softly through the storm,
and never played the game.

I carried hope through years of pain,
believed in hearts unseen.
Endurance is to love again,
even when love won't convene.

Rising up when all feels lost,
holding steady, standing true.
Endurance is the quiet cost
of loving what won't love you.

~K. E. Laine

Echoes of Understanding
Discovering Truth

The following reflections are representative composites inspired by the real emotions and patterns described by adults and children who have experienced parental alienation. They are shared to offer understanding and hope to anyone currently enduring the pain of PA. These accounts are illustrative narratives, not the direct words of specific individuals and were recreated after hearing similar recounts during my own research. I have included these to help readers recognize common experiences and emotional truths people feel after realizing they were a victim of parental alienation.

Adult Age 24:

"I can't believe I didn't see it before. For so long, I thought I was just being loyal to Mom. I thought I was protecting her, helping her feel better. But now I realize I was being used. I was being made to choose, to feel guilty, to hide my feelings, even about the parent I love. It makes me feel angry at first, angry that someone I trusted would twist my feelings and my memories. I feel sad, too, because I see all the moments I missed out on, all the times I doubted myself, all the love I pushed away without knowing it.

Most of all, I feel confused. I don't know who I can trust anymore. I don't want to lose my relationship with either parent, but I also don't want to feel like a pawn. I'm learning that it's not my fault, that I wasn't supposed to carry someone else's guilt or resentment. I'm just me, and I'm allowed to love both of my parents without shame.

It's hard to forgive, and it's hard to understand why it happened. But I'm starting to trust my own feelings again. I'm starting to see that my relationships don't have to be a battlefield. And even though it hurts, I know I can rebuild love and trust on my own terms."

Adult Age 28:

"I also feel wary. I question my instincts, my memories, even my own heart. Who can I trust? How do I know my feelings are

really mine? But slowly, I'm learning that it's okay to reclaim my emotions. It's okay to love both of my parents without guilt. It's okay to just be me."

Adult Age 34:

"I didn't realize until much later how much I missed out on. As a child, I thought I was just being careful, loyal, doing what I was supposed to do. But now I see that so many moments with my dad and with our family were taken from me. Birthdays, vacations, ordinary afternoons that should have been filled with laughter… I missed them because I was being manipulated into feeling guilty for being happy or close with him."

"It makes me ache to think about all the little things I didn't get to experience, the stories I don't fully remember, the traditions I didn't get to be a part of. I see now that I wasn't choosing to miss these things; I was being pushed away without even understanding it at the time."

"Even though it's painful to look back, I'm learning to reclaim those memories in my mind, to imagine the moments I was denied, and to hold onto the love that was always there, even if it was interrupted. I can feel the joy I was supposed to have, and I'm learning that it's never too late to nurture those connections, even as an adult."

Teenager Age 13:

"I thought I was helping Mom by saying Dad was mean, but really, I was just repeating what she said. It feels weird to realize I wasn't really angry at Dad, I just thought I had to be."

Teenager Age 14:

"I remember pretending I didn't care about going to Dad's because Mom would get sad. I felt like I was doing the right thing, but inside, I just missed him and wanted to be honest about it."

Conclusion:

Getting through parental alienation is not easy. It is a test of endurance, of love, and of moral courage. It is possible, though, and through it, you learn that your value does not depend on your children's recognition. Your heart can survive the ache, and your love, patient, unwavering, and true, can outlast even the most determined attempts to erase it.

Resources
Scripts and Templates

Clear, calm communication for high-conflict co-parenting

If there is one thing we wish we had understood earlier, it is this: co-parenting is not always possible, and continuing to chase it can do more harm than good.

For a long time, we believed that better communication would fix everything. If we stayed calmer, explained ourselves more clearly, or showed enough flexibility, we thought we could reach a healthy co-parenting relationship. Instead, every attempt at collaboration turned into conflict. Every exchange reopened old wounds. The idea of "working together for the kids" sounded right, but in practice it created constant tension and emotional fallout. We did not consciously choose parallel parenting. There was no defining moment or expert who named it for us at the time. Over the course of a year, we simply began changing our behavior to protect ourselves. We communicated less because every interaction came at a cost. We stopped explaining ourselves because explanations were used against us. We reduced engagement because engagement only escalated situations. Without fully realizing it, we narrowed our focus to what we could control: our home, our time with the kids, and the stability we provided while they were with us. Only later did we understand that this approach had a name. Parallel parenting.

As the patterns became clearer, the manipulation, the unresolved cycles of conflict, and the emotional toll of constant "cooperation," we became more intentional. We stopped trying to manage someone else's reactions and started managing our own boundaries. That realization was validating and frustrating at the same time. Validating because it confirmed we were not imagining the damage this dynamic was causing. Frustrating because it revealed how long we had stayed in a system that required us to shrink and absorb conflict in the name of being reasonable. Parallel parenting did not emerge as a strategy. It emerged as self-preservation. We did not disengage because we did not care. We disengaged because communication, as it existed, was unsafe.

Once we understood what parallel parenting actually was, everything changed. Life became quieter, more predictable, and more stable. The reduction in chaos was not accidental. It came from removing ourselves from a dynamic that depended on our participation to continue. In hindsight, we wish we had recognized this sooner. Not because it would have made things perfect, but because it would have given us permission to stop trying to fix something that was never within our control.

Parallel parenting is a structure in which communication is limited, brief, and business-like. Communication happens in writing whenever possible. Topics are restricted to essential logistics such as schedules, school information, and medical needs. There is no debating, no revisiting the past, and no emotional processing beyond what is legally required. This approach can feel counterintuitive, especially if you were taught that good parents always work together. In high-conflict situations, less communication often creates more peace. We use the shared parenting plan as our sole guide. If something is not addressed in that document, we do not engage. When communication is required, we follow the plan exactly as written.
We cannot control the messages we receive, but we can control our response. That distinction has been critical for our mental health and stability. We now use the *Grey Rock* method in all required communication and will continue to do so until our younger child ages out of the shared parenting plan. For anyone navigating a high-conflict co-parent dynamic, parallel parenting is not a failure. It is a way to protect your peace and provide consistency for your children when cooperation is no longer possible.

Why the Grey Rock Method Matters

The Grey Rock Method helps you stay calm and nonreactive when a high-conflict parent tries to provoke you. By keeping responses short, neutral, and emotion-free, you take away the payoff they get from creating drama. It protects your energy,

keeps communication focused on the child, and creates written messages that hold up under legal or professional review.

Families caught in parental alienation don't just face emotional pain, they face a constant communication battle. Every message, every appointment, every interaction can feel like a test. Many parents and stepparents find themselves walking into conversations unprepared or overwhelmed, unsure how to stay calm, protect themselves, or keep communication focused on the child.

Why These Templates Are Important

When you're overwhelmed, scared, or exhausted, finding the "right" words is nearly impossible. These templates give you steady, neutral language you can use instantly, without feeding conflict or giving the other parent anything to twist. They help you communicate like the safe, stable parent your child needs.

I included these templates because I wish I'd had tools like this while navigating our own story. They would have saved time, emotional energy, and so many painful misunderstandings. My hope is that they do that for you.
Having the tools to protect your children and yourself is the first step in regaining truth.

Every script is designed to help you:
- de-escalate conflict
- maintain emotional boundaries
- communicate clearly and safely
- document interactions without sounding reactive
- support your child without feeding the conflict
- stay grounded when the other parent is not
- avoid the traps that high-conflict communication creates

Alienation creates chaos. Structure helps restore clarity.
These tools are here to support you in the moments when words are hardest to find and when they matter most.

Families caught in parental alienation don't just face emotional pain, they face a constant communication battle. Every message, every appointment, every interaction can feel like a test. Many parents and stepparents find themselves walking into conversations unprepared or overwhelmed, unsure how to stay calm, protect themselves, or keep communication focused on the child.

Section 1: Grey Rock Text Message Templates

Short. Neutral. No emotion. No interpretation. Factual only.

Basic Neutral Responses

1. "Noted."
2. "I will review and respond if needed."
3. "Thank you for the update."
4. "Please send that in writing."
5. "I'll be available during my parenting time."

Boundary Responses

6. "I'll answer questions related to the children only."
7. "I'm not able to discuss personal matters."
8. "Let's keep communication focused on schedules and needs."

Clarifying Responses

9. "Can you clarify the specific request?"
10. "Please provide the exact date/time you are referring to."

De-Escalation Responses

11. "I'm not able to engage in conflict. Stick to facts, please."
12. "I'll respond once communication becomes respectful."

Scheduling Responses

13. “The children will be dropped off at ___ at ___. ”

14. “Please confirm pickup details in writing.”

Section 2: Email Scripts for High Conflict Co-parents

Professional tone. Assumes everything may be read by a lawyer, GAL, or judge.

Script 1- Schedule Clarification

Subject: Clarification of Parenting Time

Hi [Name],
I'm confirming the upcoming parenting time schedule to avoid any confusion.

Based on the current agreement:
• My time begins: _____
• My time ends: _____

If you believe any part is inaccurate, please reply with the corrected details.

Thank you,
[Your Name]

Script 2- Request for Information (School/Medical)

Subject: Request for Information

Hi [Name],
Please send the school/medical update that you referenced earlier. I need this information to stay informed and support our child consistently.

Thank you,
[Your Name]

Script 3- Responding to Accusations

Subject: Re: Your Message

Hi [Name],
I've received your message. I will not engage in accusations. If you have a specific concern related to the children's safety, schedule, or wellbeing, please state it clearly.

Best,
[Your Name]

Script 4 -Documenting Interference

Subject: Documentation of Missed Contact

Hi [Name],
I attempted to complete scheduled parenting time on [date/time], but was unable to due to [child not available / refusal / incorrect location].

I am documenting this for clarity. Please confirm how we can prevent this issue going forward.

Thank you,
[Your Name]

Section 3: School and Teacher Communication Templates

Script 1-Teacher Introduction Email

Subject: Introduction & Communication Request

Hi [Teacher Name],
I'm [Name], the [mother/father/stepparent] of [Child]. I want to support their school experience and ensure we remain on the same page.

If concerns arise-academic, social, emotional-please copy me on communication or send me a brief note so I can follow up at home.

Thank you for your partnership,
[Your Name]

Script 2-When the Other Parent Blocks School Information

Subject: Access to Records / Information

Hi [School Staff],
I'm requesting copies of all academic and attendance updates for [Child]. I am a legal parent/guardian and want to stay engaged in their progress.

Please send:
- Report cards
- Attendance notes
- Behavior updates
- Teacher communication summaries

Thank you,
[Your Name]

Script 3-If Your Child Shares Concerning Behavior

Subject: Concern Regarding Student Wellbeing

Hi [Teacher],
[Child] shared something concerning with us: "[summary in child's words]."
Can you let me know if you've observed anything similar at school?

I appreciate your awareness and support,
[Your Name]

Script 4-When You Disagree About Holding the Child Accountable

Subject: Support for Holding [Child's Name] Accountable

Hi [Teacher Name],
I wanted to clarify my perspective regarding expectations for [Child] at school. I understand that [Other Parent] may feel differently, but I believe that holding [Child] accountable—academically and behaviorally—is important for their growth and consistency.

Please feel free to:
- reinforce classroom expectations,
- apply appropriate consequences, and
- communicate any concerns directly with me.

I fully support you in doing what's developmentally appropriate and aligned with your classroom standards. My goal is to help [Child] learn responsibility and feel supported by consistent expectations across both homes and school.

Thank you for everything you do for [Child],
[Your Name]

Script 5- When You Disagree With the Other Parent

Subject: Clarifying Information for [Child's Name]

Hi [Teacher Name],
I wanted to reach out regarding something that may have been shared with you by [Other Parent]. I have a different understanding of the situation, and I want to make sure you have accurate information so we can all support [Child] consistently.

Here is my understanding:
- [State your version briefly, factually]
- [Any relevant details the teacher needs]

I'm not asking you to take sides—I just want to make sure communication stays clear and that [Child]'s needs remain the focus. If you've noticed anything in class that could help us better understand what's going on, I'm always open to hearing your perspective.

Thank you for everything you do for [Child],
[Your Name]
[Your Contact Info]

Section 4: Therapist and Doctor Communication

These scripts avoid sounding hostile toward the other parent while still addressing manipulation or withheld information.

Script 1 - Therapist: Sharing Concerns Without Attacking

Hi [Therapist],
I'd like to share a concern that may impact [Child] emotionally.

Recently, I became aware of [behavior/incident] that may be affecting their sense of safety or attachment. I want to ensure therapy reflects the full picture so treatment supports their best interests.

If helpful, I can provide examples or documentation.

Thank you for helping us support [Child],
[Your Name]

Script 2- Doctor: When the Other Parent Is Withholding Information

Subject: Important Background Information for [Child's Name]

Hi Dr. [Last Name],
I wanted to share a concern that may be relevant to [Child]'s care. I recently learned that some medical or emotional information may not have been communicated to you or shared between both parents. To make sure nothing is overlooked, I want to provide you with the full picture as I understand it.

Here is the information I have:
• [Brief factual point]

- [Brief factual point]
- [Child's behavior/symptoms you've noticed]

I'm not looking to blame anyone—my goal is simply to ensure that you have accurate, complete information so [Child] can receive appropriate care and support.

If there's anything you need from me, or if you prefer updates in a specific format, please let me know.

Thank you for helping us support [Child],
[Your Name]
[Your Contact Information]

Script 3 - Therapist: When Information Is Not Communicated with Both Parents

Hi [Therapist],
It has come to my attention that some important emotional or medical information was not shared with both parents. To ensure [Child] receives appropriate care, I want to verify that all relevant concerns are communicated accurately.

Please include both parents in updates or requests for information.

Thank you,
[Your Name]

Script 4 - Pediatrician/Psychiatrist: Suspected Anxiety/Depression

Hi Dr. [Name],
I'm concerned that [Child] may be experiencing symptoms related to anxiety/depression. At home, we've noticed:

- _____
- _____
- _____

I want to ensure nothing is overlooked and that we approach treatment holistically.

Thank you,
[Your Name]

Section 5: Documentation Templates

Short, clear, factual logs. No emotion. No speculation. Create a folder to save all email communication. Back up text messages and keep most forms of communication in written form. There are also court appointed apps. We used "Our Family Wizard" to communicate, which can be accessed by the court for all forms of communication after our court case.

1. Incident Log Template:

Date:
Time:
Event:
Child's behavior:
Other parent's behavior:
What was said (exact wording if possible):
My response:
Witnesses (if any):
Attachments (texts, emails, screenshots):

2. Missed Parenting Time Log

Date:
Scheduled time:
What happened:
Child's explanation:
Other parent's explanation (if any):
Attempts to resolve:
Notes:

3. Positive Contact Log

(Use if you believe you need evidence for the court)

Date:
Activity:
Child's mood:
Positive moments:
Any setbacks:
Follow-up ideas:

4. Other Topics to Document When Needed

Communication

- Emails, texts, calls
- Missed or blocked communication
- Hostile, manipulative, or confusing messages

Parenting Time

- Missed visits
- Late or early exchanges
- Refusals or interference

Transitions

- Child's mood before and after
- Exact wording the child uses
- Parent behavior at pickup/drop-off

Child's Emotional/Behavioral Changes

- Anxiety, withdrawal, anger
- Regression (sleep, eating, hygiene)
- Sudden loyalty shifts or “adult-like” phrases

Child Statements

- Exact words
- New or distorted “memories”
- Signs of coaching

School

- Missing work
- Attendance issues
- Behavior notes
- School info not shared with you

Medical/Mental Health

- Symptoms
- Missed or hidden appointments
- Medication issues
- Advice from providers not passed along

Interference

- Withholding school or medical info
- Blocking communication
- Negative or undermining messages to the child

Your Positive Efforts

- Calls and check-ins
- Attending events or appointments
- Helping with schoolwork
- Attempts to coordinate schedules

Safety Concerns

- Concerning injuries
- Unsafe conditions reported by the child

Parenting Plan Issues

- Violations
- Refusal to cooperate
- False allegations

Section 6: Communication Starters

Neutral Phrases

Use these anytime communication starts to escalate.

- *I'm focusing on solutions."*
- *"Let's stick to the parenting schedule."*
- *"I'm not able to discuss personal topics."*
- *"Please restate that as a specific request."*
- *"I disagree with your interpretation."*
- *"I'll follow the court order."*
- *"I'm documenting this interaction."*
- *"Let's return to child-focused communication."*

Calm Communication Starters

These help you start conversations without feeding conflict.

- "Here's the information I have so far…"
- "Let's focus on the child's needs."
- "What solution are you proposing?"
- "I'm open to reviewing that with you."
- "Let's double-check the calendar together."

Responses to Hostile Messages

Never mirror hostility. Use these to stay steady.

- "I will respond when communication is respectful."
- "This topic isn't appropriate. Please focus on the children."
- "Your interpretation is noted. I disagree."
- "This message will be saved for documentation."
- "I'm ending this conversation for now."

Parental Anchor Statements (Quotes for yourself)

These keep you grounded when your nervous system is overloaded.

- "This moment is temporary."
- "I can stay steady even when the situation isn't."
- "I don't have to fix their behavior, only my response."
- "My child's rejection is about pressure, not about love."
- "I am the safe parent. I act like the safe parent."

Section 7: When Your Child Says X… You Say Y

These scripts de-escalate and reduce loyalty pressure.

1. When child repeats negative things about you

Child: "Mom/Dad says you don't care about me."
You: "I'm sorry that was said to you. My love for you is steady, even when things feel confusing."

2. When child refuses time with you

Child: "I don't want to go."
You: "I hear that. We'll take it slow, and you're safe with me."

3. When child repeats a distorted story

Child: "You did ___."
You: "I remember that differently, but I'm glad you told me how you feel."

4. When child seems afraid to enjoy time with you

Child: "I can't tell Mom/Dad we had fun."
You: "It's okay to enjoy time in both homes. You're not doing anything wrong."

5. When child asks who is “right”

Child: “Who is telling the truth?”
You: “Adults sometimes see things differently. What matters most is that you’re safe and loved.”

6. When child feels torn

Child: “I feel stuck between you.”
You: “You don’t have to choose. You’re allowed to love both parents fully.”

Section 8: How to Tell Professionals / GAL / Court About Parental Alienation

(Neutral, factual, professional wording)

Script 1-

Subject: Concerns Regarding [Child's Name]'s Emotional and Attachment Changes

Hi [Name],
I want to share some concerns about changes I've observed in [Child], because I believe they may be relevant to their emotional wellbeing and the decisions being made about their care.

Over the past several months, I've noticed the following patterns:

• Sudden and intense rejection of me without a clear triggering event
• Statements that sound coached or far beyond [Child]'s typical language
• Black-and-white thinking ("one parent all good, one all bad")
• Fear, guilt, or distress around showing affection toward me
• A significant shift in attitude immediately after leaving the other home
• Refusal to share positive experiences because they "aren't allowed" or "will get in trouble"
• Repetition of accusations or narratives that don't match history or the child's lived experience

I'm not making accusations about the other parent.
My concern is solely focused on the **impact these patterns may be having on [Child]**, their mental health, and their sense of stability between homes.

My goals are:
• to make sure [Child] has emotional safety in both homes
• to ensure professionals have the full picture
• to support a healthy relationship between [Child] and both parents

If it would be helpful, I can provide specific examples, dates, or documentation of when these patterns began and how they've developed.

Thank you for considering this information and for supporting [Child] through this process.
[Your Name]

Script 2-Shorter Version (if you need it brief)

Hi [Name],
I'm concerned about some recent changes in [Child]'s behavior that may point to loyalty conflicts or pressure in the other home. I'm seeing sudden rejection, scripted statements, fear of upsetting the other parent, and black-and-white thinking that doesn't match our relationship history.

I'm not accusing the other parent—I just want to make sure these patterns are documented and considered, as they may impact [Child]'s wellbeing. I can provide examples if needed.
Thank you,
[Your Name]

Resources
Leading Experts in the Parental Alienation

If parental alienation is a concern, the following experts and podcasts offer publicly available educational information that may support understanding and awareness. These resources are independent, and there is no affiliation between the listed individuals or organizations and this book. These were starting points for my own research after discovering Parental Alienation.

Leading Experts

Dr. Amy J. L. Baker

Dr. Baker is a nationally recognized expert in parental alienation, child development, and emotional abuse. She has authored or co-authored more than ten books and over 120 academic articles related to children's well-being. Her notable works include *Surviving Parental Alienation* and *Adult Children of Parental Alienation Syndrome: Breaking the Ties That Bind.*

Website: amyjlbaker.com

Dr. Craig Childress

Dr. Childress is a clinical psychologist known for his extensive work on attachment-based parental alienation. He focuses on the intersection of attachment trauma, personality disorder dynamics, and disrupted parent–child relationships. His book *Foundations* and his online educational materials outline how alienation develops, how it affects children, and how targeted parents can respond using evidence-informed approaches.

Website: drcraigchildress.com

Dr. William Bernet

Dr. Bernet is a psychiatrist and a leading authority on parental alienation. He has edited *Parental Alienation: Science and Law,* which provides up-to-date information on the clinical, research, and legal issues surrounding alienation.

Website: www.familyaccessfightingforchildrensrights.com/dr-william-bernet

Dr. Richard Warshak

Dr. Warshak is a clinical psychologist and author of *Divorce Poison,* a seminal book discussing the effects of parental alienation on children and strategies for healing and prevention.

Website: warshak.com

Dr. J. Michael Bone

Dr. Bone is a clinical psychologist and leading expert in parental alienation. He co-authored *Co-Parenting with a Toxic Ex* with Dr. Amy Baker, which offers practical strategies for managing high-conflict co-parenting situations.

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Podcasts

The Parental Alienation Project Podcast
Hosted by the team behind the Parental Alienation Project, this podcast shares real stories, expert interviews, and evidence-based discussions on the effects of parental alienation. Each episode explores how alienation develops, its emotional and legal impact, and the steps parents can take toward healing and reconnection. The focus is on awareness, education, and recovery, helping families understand that they are not alone in their experience.

Beyond the High Road of Parental Alienation
Hosted by Shelby Milford, this podcast focuses on healing, empowerment, and rebuilding life after alienation.

Parental Alienation: From Couch to Courtroom and Beyond
Hosted by Dr. Bob Evans and the National Association of Parental Alienation Specialists (NAOPAS), this show explores both the psychological and legal aspects of PA.

The Family Disappeared Podcast
This podcast features community stories and expert insights to promote hope and awareness surrounding parental alienation.

Surviving Parental Alienation
Featuring real-life stories and guidance for parents navigating toxic co-parenting and alienation.

Navigating Parental Alienation
Hosted by Jacqueline, this series interviews parents, mental health clinicians, and legal professionals, providing tools for reconnection

and understanding.

The KICK-ASS Stepmom Podcast

Jaime Scrimgeour is a supportive, honest resource for stepmothers navigating the realities of blended family life. Through candid conversations, expert insight, and lived experience, the podcast addresses the emotional, relational, and often unspoken challenges stepmoms face, offering clarity, validation, and practical tools for moving forward.

Parental Alienation Behavior Checklists

Inspired by core themes identified in the work of Dr. Amy J. L. Baker

(17 caregiver actions associated with parental alienation)

- ☐ **1. Speaking negatively about the other parent in front of the child**
- ☐ **2. Reducing or disrupting the child's time with the other parent**
- ☐ **3. Blocking or interrupting normal communication between the child and the other parent**
- ☐ **4. Removing or discouraging reminders of the other parent (photos, traditions, routines)**
- ☐ **5. Giving or withholding affection depending on the child's loyalty**
- ☐ **6. Telling the child the other parent does not care about them**
- ☐ **7. Steering the child toward "choosing" one parent over the other**
- ☐ **8. Suggesting or implying the other parent is unsafe or harmful**
- ☐ **9. Sharing adult conflicts, worries, or emotional burdens with the child**
- ☐ **10. Pressuring the child to distance themselves from the other parent**
- ☐ **11. Making the child feel disloyal or wrong for wanting a relationship with the other parent**
- ☐ **12. Creating situations that push the child to take one parent's side**
- ☐ **13. Minimizing or erasing the child's prior positive relationship with the other parent**
- ☐ **14. Trying to reshape the child's identity to exclude the other parent**

☐ **15. Limiting the targeted parent's role in school, medical, or activity involvement**
☐ **16. Asking the child to report on the other parent's private life or home**
☐ **17. Expecting the child to carry messages or emotional weight between parents**

How Children May Respond When Alienation Occurs

Inspired by core themes identified in the work of Dr. Amy J. L. Baker

(8 common behavioral and emotional patterns in affected children)

☐ **1. Sharp or sudden rejection of one parent without a clear explanation**
☐ **2. Explanations that sound rehearsed, borrowed, or too adult for the child's age**
☐ **3. Viewing one parent as entirely "good" and the other as entirely "bad"**
☐ **4. Showing no guilt or hesitation when rejecting or criticizing the targeted parent**
☐ **5. Automatically siding with the favored parent in any conflict or disagreement**
☐ **6. Describing distorted, exaggerated, or false memories about the targeted parent**
☐ **7. Rejecting the targeted parent's extended family and support network**
☐ **8. Insisting the rejection is entirely their own idea, despite clear outside influence**

Acknowledgment

This checklist is an original interpretation drawing on themes described in the research of **Dr. Amy J. L. Baker**, whose work explores common patterns in parental alienation dynamics.
For background reading, see:
Baker, A. J. L. (2007). *Adult Children of Parental Alienation Syndrome*. W. W. Norton & Company.

Disclaimer

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